

क ख ग घ

BOOK 1 · PRONUNCIATION & SCRIPT

Sounds, Script & the Delhi Accent

Where to put your tongue, how to read and write Devanagari, and the drills that make it stick.

JACOB'S DELHI HINDI COURSE

A complete six-month self-study program · Standard Hindi of Delhi (Khari Boli) · 2026

Contents

Before You Start — How to Read Every Entry in This Course	3
Chapter 1 — Your Mouth, the Map: How Hindi Sound Works	5
Chapter 2 — The Vowels: Length, Purity & the Nose	9
Chapter 3 — Dental vs. Retroflex: The Big One	13
Chapter 4 — Aspiration: The Puff That Changes Words	16
Chapter 5 — The Tricky Customers	19
Chapter 6 — The Invisible Vowel: Schwa & the Vanishing Act	22
Chapter 7 — Rhythm, Melody & Sounding Delhi	24
Chapter 8 — The Complete Alphabet, Letter by Letter	26
Chapter 9 — Matras, Conjuncts & How Words Assemble	39
Chapter 10 — Writing Devanagari I: Vowels & the First Rows	48
Chapter 11 — Writing Devanagari II: The Rest, Digits & Whole Words	52
Chapter 12 — Minimal-Pair Drills: Train Your Ear & Mouth	60
Chapter 13 — Self-Tests, Partner Games & the Gauntlet	68

BEFORE YOU START

How to Read Every Entry in This Course

Every Hindi word and sentence in all of these books appears in **three layers**, always in the same order:

मैं दिल्ली में रहता हूँ।

main dillee mein rehtaa hoon. [meh(n) dil-lee may(n) reh-tah hoo(n)]

I live in Delhi.

Line 1 — Devanagari, the real Hindi script. Even in week 1, let your eyes rest on it before reading the other lines; recognition builds silently. **Line 2 — Roman** (*italics*), Hindi in English letters, spelled the way this course always spells it. **Line 3 — Say it** [in brackets], a phonetic respelling an American can read cold, hyphenated by syllable.

The Roman spelling system (training wheels with rules)

Long vowels doubled	<i>a / aa</i> (अ/आ), <i>i / ee</i> (इ/ई), <i>u / oo</i> (उ/ऊ) — so की is <i>kee</i> , का is <i>kaa</i>
CAPITALS = retroflex	<i>T Th D Dh N R Rh</i> (ट ठ ड ढ ण ढ ढ) — tongue curled back. Lowercase <i>t th d dh n</i> (त थ द ध न) = dental, tongue on the teeth. This is the single most useful habit in this course.
h = puff of air	<i>kh gh chh jh Th Dh th dh ph bh</i> are one sound each, said with extra breath
Urdu-flavored letters	<i>z</i> (ज़), <i>f</i> (फ़), <i>q</i> (क़) — Delhi speech is full of z and f
Nasal vowels	Roman keeps a plain <i>n</i> (<i>haan, mein, hoon</i>); the phonetic line shows the truth with (n): [hah(n)] — air through the nose, tongue touches nothing

Reading the phonetic line

uh	अ, like the a in <i>about</i>	ah	आ, as in <i>father</i>
i / ee	इ as in <i>bit</i> / ई as in <i>feet</i>	u / oo	उ as in <i>put</i> / ऊ as in <i>food</i>
ay	ए, like <i>say</i> but pure — freeze the vowel, no glide at the end	eh	ऐ, like <i>bed</i> held a beat longer (this is the Delhi value — है = [heh])
oh	ओ, like <i>go</i> but pure, no glide	aw	औ, like <i>law</i> with rounded lips (Delhi value — और = [awr])

Doubled consonants are split across the hyphen and genuinely held: दिल्ली [dil-lee] — park your tongue on the l for an extra beat. There are no stress capitals: Hindi syllables are far more even than English; the long vowels carry the weight naturally.

Other marks you'll meet

(m)/(f) after a noun is its gender — always learn it with the word. (vt)/(vi) marks verbs that do/don't take *ne* in the past (a Unit 14 story). (lit. ...) is a word-for-word gloss so you can see the Hindi skeleton. The bar | is the Hindi full stop.

NOTE

Two honest wrinkles, so they never confuse you: (1) written Hindi has वह/यह for he/she/it/this/that, but Delhi mouths say *voh* and *yeh*, and casual writing uses वो/ये freely — you'll see both in this course, exactly as you will in real life. (2) Everyday Delhi Hindi happily uses English words (स्कूल, फ़ोन, मेट्रो, टाइम); that's not "cheating," that's the dialect.

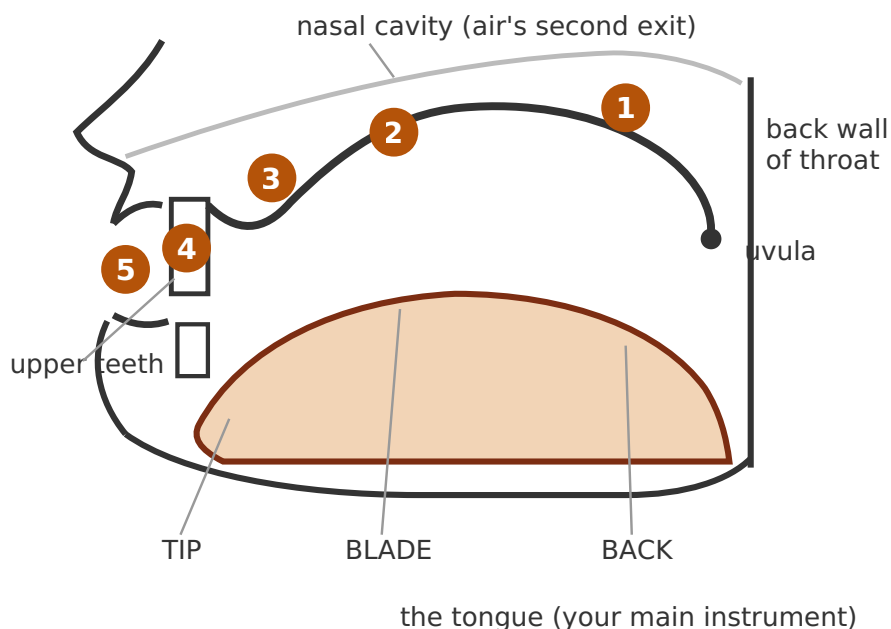
CHAPTER 1

Your Mouth, the Map: How Hindi Sound Works

Here is the best-kept secret of Hindi pronunciation: **the alphabet is a map of your mouth**. Devanagari isn't an arbitrary pile of letters the way A-Z is — it's a grid, organized by *where your tongue is* and *what your breath is doing*. Learn to feel five tongue positions and two breath switches, and all thirty-odd consonants snap into place like keys on a keyboard. That's why this book starts in your mouth, not on the page.

One promise before we start: you do not need a perfect accent. You need about six contrasts that Hindi ears rely on to tell words apart — miss those and *kal* (yesterday) becomes *khal* (villain), or a polite word becomes a rude one. Nail those six and every Delhi aunty will beam at you. Your partner is your secret weapon here: their ear is already perfectly tuned, and Chapter 13 gives you ready-made two-minute games to borrow it.

The map itself



Side view of the mouth, facing left. The numbered dots are the five "home bases" every Hindi consonant lives at — the same five rows you'll meet in the alphabet.

The five home bases (feel each one now)

Say each English word below slowly and *notice where your tongue lands*. You already own every position except one — Hindi just asks you to use them more precisely.

BASE	WHERE	FEEL IT WITH	HINDI ROW (PREVIEW)
1	Soft palate — back of tongue rises to the soft rear roof	say "go", "king" — feel the back hump up	<i>k kh g gh</i> (क ख ग घ)
2	Front dome — blade of tongue against the front of the hard palate	say "cheese", "jam"	<i>ch chh j jh</i> (च छ ज झ)
3	Curled back (RETROFLEX) — tip curls up and back; the <i>underside</i> of the tip taps the bumpy ridge behind the teeth. The one new position — Chapter 3 trains it.	say "herd" and hold the r — many Americans curl the tip; now tap the roof from that curl	<i>T Th D Dh</i> <i>N</i> (ट ठ ड ढ ण)
4	Teeth (DENTAL) — tip pressed flat on the back of the upper teeth, farther forward than any English t/d	say "width" — the d slides to the teeth for the th; that forward contact is home base 4	<i>t th d dh n</i> (त थ द ध न)
5	Lips	say "me", "pie"	<i>p ph b bh m</i> (प फ ब भ म)

IN YOUR MOUTH

The trap for English speakers sits between bases 3 and 4. Your everyday English t/d lives on the ridge — *exactly halfway between* Hindi's dental त and retroflex ट. Stay there and every t you say is a coin-flip to a Hindi ear. The fix is simple to state and takes two weeks of reps: **push forward to the teeth for त, curl up and back for ट, and never park on the ridge again.**

The genius of the grid

Now watch what the alphabet does with those five bases. Each base gets a row, and each row runs through the same four-step breath pattern, plus its nasal:

	VOICELESS	VOICELESS + PUFF	VOICED	VOICED + BREATHY	NASAL
1 soft palate	क <i>ka</i>	ख <i>kha</i>	ग <i>ga</i>	घ <i>gha</i>	ङ <i>nga</i>
2 front dome	च <i>cha</i>	छ <i>chha</i>	ज <i>ja</i>	झ <i>jha</i>	ञ <i>nya</i>

	VOICELESS	VOICELESS + PUFF	VOICED	VOICED + BREATHY	NASAL
3 curled back	ट <i>Ta</i>	ठ <i>Tha</i>	ड <i>Da</i>	ढ <i>Dha</i>	ण <i>Na</i>
4 teeth	त <i>ta</i>	थ <i>tha</i>	द <i>da</i>	ध <i>dha</i>	न <i>na</i>
5 lips	प <i>pa</i>	फ <i>pha</i>	ब <i>ba</i>	भ <i>bha</i>	म <i>ma</i>

Twenty-five consonants, one pattern. When a Hindi teacher says a letter is "the fourth letter of the ट row," they've told you everything: position 3, voiced, breathy. The leftover letters (य र ल व, the s-sounds, ह, and the Urdu guests ज्ञ क़ क़) get their own tour in Chapters 5 and 8.

The two breath switches

Every row above is just one tongue position with two switches flipped on or off:

Switch 1 — Voice. Put two fingers on your throat and say ssss then zzzz. That buzz is voicing. क/ट/त/प are buzz-off; ग/ड/द/ब are buzz-on. English has this switch too, so it's free.

Switch 2 — The puff (aspiration). Hold your palm an inch from your lips. Say "pin" — you'll feel a little explosion of air. Say "spin" — almost none. English flips this switch automatically and never uses it to tell words apart. **Hindi uses it to tell words apart constantly**, which is why Chapter 4 exists. The *h* in *kh*, *th*, *bh*... is that puff, not a separate h-sound.

How to practice anything in this book

Use this loop for every new sound, five minutes at a time: **(1) Position** — read the "in your mouth" instruction, place your tongue silently, hold it, feel it. **(2) Slow motion** — produce the sound absurdly slowly three times; speed hides errors, slowness exposes them. **(3) Contrast** — say it against its neighbor (*ta-Ta*, *ka-kha*) ten times, exaggerating the difference. **(4) Word** — drop it into the example words. **(5) Ear check** — once or twice a week, run a Chapter 13 partner game; being *heard* correctly is the only score that counts. A phone voice memo is a fine substitute on solo days: record, wait an hour, listen cold.

DELHI STREET NOTE

Triage, Delhi edition: if your bandwidth is limited, spend it in this order — **(1) dental vs. retroflex**, **(2) the puff**, **(3) vowel length** (*kam* vs *kaam*), **(4) nasal vowels**. Delhiites will forgive a soft व or a flat र forever, but ट-vs-त confusions genuinely change words, and aspiration slips can turn innocent words rude. The good news: your partner's family will find a careful dental त more impressive than any amount of vocabulary.

WITH YOUR PARTNER

Tonight's two-minute game: have your partner say these four pairs at random while you point — *kal/khal · Taal/taal · dam/daam · haan/hah*. Then swap roles and let them grade you. Log your score; you'll rerun this in Week 4 and feel like a different person.

CHAPTER 2

The Vowels: Length, Purity & the Nose

Hindi vowels are easier than English vowels — there are fewer of them and they never do the sneaky reductions English loves. But they demand two disciplines English never taught you: **length** (short vs. long changes the word) and **purity** (no sliding). Add the nose (nasalization) and you have the whole system.

Discipline 1 — Length is meaning

In English, saying "beeeeach" long or short is just emphasis. In Hindi, length is vocabulary:

कम / काम · दिन / दीन · सुनना / सूना

kam / kaam · din / deen · sunnaa / soonaa [kum / kahm · din / deen · sun-nah / soo-nah]

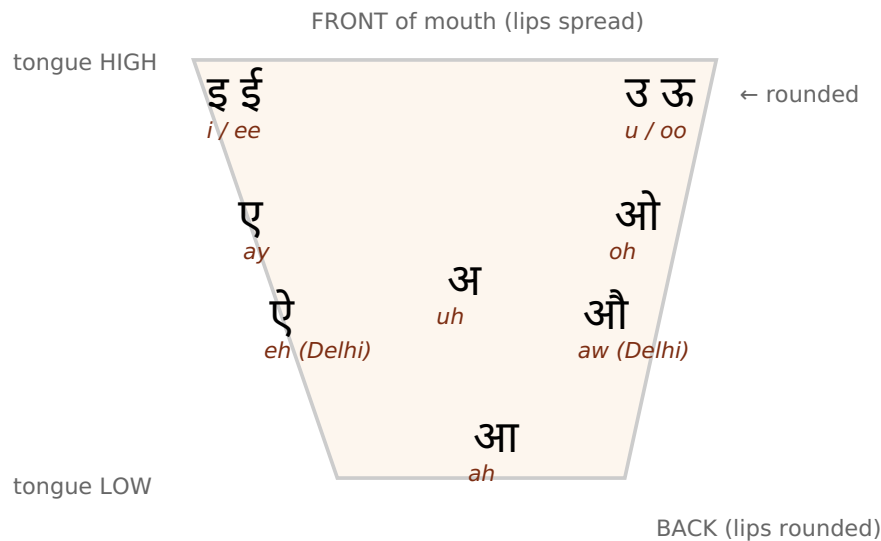
less / work · day / poor · to listen / deserted

Rule of thumb: a long vowel takes roughly *twice* the time of a short one. When practicing, exaggerate — make the long ones luxurious. Native speakers never mis-hear an over-long आ, but an under-long one becomes a different word.

Discipline 2 — Freeze the vowel (no glides)

Say English "day" slowly: your mouth starts at "deh" and glides up to "ee" — that's a diphthong. Hindi ए is the *starting position only*, frozen. Same for ओ: English "go" ends in a little "oo" glide; Hindi ओ holds still. The trick: say the vowel and **hold it for three seconds without letting anything move** — jaw, lips, tongue all parked. If the sound stays identical from start to finish, it's pure.

The vowel map



Where each vowel lives: height = how high the tongue body sits, left-right = front vs. back, and the back column rounds the lips.

Vowel by vowel

LETTER	ROMAN · SAY IT	HOW TO MAKE IT	ANCHOR WORDS
अ	a · uh	Total relaxation — the vowel of <i>about</i> . Jaw loose, tongue flat. Never the "a" of <i>cat</i> .	अब <i>ab</i> [ub] now
आ	aa · ah	Drop the jaw — doctor's "say ahh." Long; give it two beats.	आप <i>aap</i> [ahp] you
इ	i · i	Short and light, as in <i>bit</i> . Quick — don't let it grow into "ee."	इधर <i>idhar</i> [i-dhur] over here
ई	ee · ee	Big smile, tongue high and forward, held long.	जी <i>jee</i> [jee] (respect word)
उ	u · u	Short, as in <i>put</i> — never the "uh" of <i>putt</i> . Lips lightly rounded.	सुन <i>sun</i> [sun] listen!
ऊ	oo · oo	Strong lip-rounding, long — the "oo" of <i>food</i> with commitment.	दूध <i>doodh</i> [doodh] milk

LETTER	ROMAN · SAY IT	HOW TO MAKE IT	ANCHOR WORDS
ए	e · ay	Mid-front, FROZEN — say minus the glide. Hold three seconds; nothing may move.	एक <i>ek</i> [ayk] one
ऐ	ai · eh	In Delhi: the vowel of <i>bed</i> , held long. Open the ए one notch. (Textbooks from other regions teach "uh-ee" — in Delhi you will simply never hear that.)	है <i>hai</i> [heh] is
ओ	o · oh	Rounded, mid-back, FROZEN — go minus the glide.	दो <i>do</i> [doh] two
औ	au · aw	In Delhi: the vowel of <i>law</i> with round lips. Open the ओ one notch.	और <i>aur</i> [awr] and
ऋ	ri · ri	Historically a vocalic r; in modern Hindi just say "ri." Rare, Sanskrit-flavored words.	ऋषि <i>rishi</i> [ri-shi] sage
ऑ	o · aw	The "office vowel" — invented for English loans; <i>hot/office</i> à l'américaine.	ऑफिस <i>ofis</i> [aw-fis] office

WATCH OUT

The two vowels Americans mangle most: अ (they say the "a" of *cat* — keep it a lazy *uh*) and ए (they add the glide — freeze it). Test yourself on बेटा *beTaa* [bay-Tah] "son": both vowels pure, no "bay-tuh," no glide.

The nose: nasalized vowels

Any Hindi vowel can also be said *through the nose*. In script it's the moon-dot ँ (candrabindu) or, when there's no room above, just the dot ं. In our system it's (n) — and here is the crucial part: **your tongue touches nothing**. It is not "an," not "ahn," there is no n-contact at the end. The velum (that soft palate from Chapter 1) simply drops and lets half the air exit through your nose while the vowel plays.

How to find it: say a long "ahhhh." Now, without stopping, think about humming — you'll feel a soft switch flip at the back and the sound turn slightly brassy. That's the velum opening. Pinch your nose shut: a plain आ sounds identical pinched or free, but a nasal आँ goes muffled and weird the instant you pinch. That's your self-test.

हाँ · कहाँ · मैं हूँ · सास / साँस

haan · kahaan · main hoon · saas / saans [hah(n) · kuh-hah(n) · meh(n) hoo(n) · sahs / sah(n)s]
yes · where · I am · mother-in-law / breath

DELHI STREET NOTE

That last pair is the classic: सास is your mother-in-law and साँस is breath — "meree saans" vs "meree saas" is a whole different sentence at a family dinner. Delhi humor being what it is, someone will absolutely make this joke at you. Nasalize with confidence and make it first.

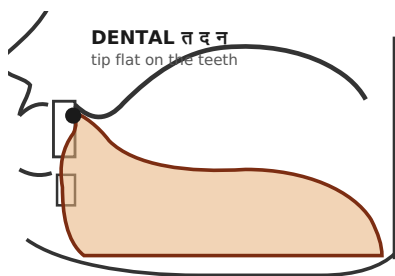
WITH YOUR PARTNER

Drill 1: partner says *haan / haa(no nasal), saas / saans, kahaa / kahaan* in random order; you call "nose!" or "no nose!" Drill 2: you say them; partner grades. Drill 3 (length): *kam/kaam, din/deen, pul/pool* — same game. Two minutes each.

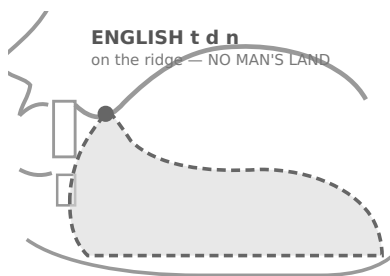
CHAPTER 3

Dental vs. Retroflex: The Big One

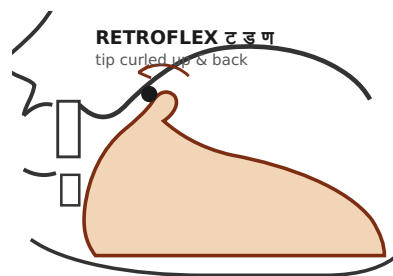
If this book could teach you only one thing, it would be this chapter. Hindi has **two complete families of t/d/n sounds**, and English speakers arrive owning neither — your English t/d sits on the ridge exactly between them. Here are the three positions, side by side:



Hindi dental: the tip presses the back of the upper front teeth — so far forward you almost bite it.



Your English habit: tip on the alveolar ridge — between the two Hindi families. Retire this position.



Hindi retroflex: the tip curls up and back; the underside of the tip taps the bumpy ridge.

Building the dental त द न (base 4)

Step 1. Find the spot: run your tongue tip down the roof of your mouth until it slides off the ridge and lands on the backs of your upper front teeth. Press gently — that's home. **Step 2.** Seal and release: with the tip pressed there, build a little air pressure and release a clean, crisp *t*. It should feel lighter and "thinner" than an English *t*, almost like the *t* in Spanish *taco* or the way "th" positions in *width*. **Step 3.** Voice it for द, add the nose for न (tip stays glued to the teeth).

IN YOUR MOUTH

Cheat code: put the very edge of the tongue tip *between* your teeth, like a lazy "th," and say *t*. Now retract it just behind the teeth. That exaggerated-forward feeling is correct — if it feels too far forward, it's probably right. Dental words to loop: तुम *tum* [tum], दिन *din* [din], नमस्ते *namaste* [nuh-muhs-tay], दाल *daal* [dahl], तीन *teen* [teen].

Building the retroflex ट ड ण (base 3)

Step 1. Curl: say American "er" and hold it — feel how the tip lifts and curls back without touching anything. That's the launch position. **Step 2.** Contact: from that curl, raise the tip until the underside touches the roof just behind the ridge. It's a small motion — you're tapping with the bottom of the tip, fingernail-side up, not the top. **Step 3.** Pop: build pressure and release. The sound is darker, rounder, more "hollow" than dental त — Indians

describe ढ as a *heavy* sound and ण as a *soft* one. Voice it for ड; ण is its nasal (rare alone, automatic in words like बाण).

IN YOUR MOUTH

Cheat code: Americans already say near-retroflex D's around r's. Say "*harder*" fast — the d after the r comes out curled. Or borrow from Indian-accent English you've heard: the way "time" and "doctor" sound in an Indian accent (*Taim*, *DaakTar*) is literally these letters — that accent exists **because Hindi ears map English t/d to retroflex**. Imitate it shamelessly: टाइम *Taim* [Tah-im], डॉक्टर *DokTar* [Dawk-Tur]. Retroflex words to loop: टमाटर *TamaaTar* [Tuh-mah-Tur], बेटा *beTaa* [bay-Tah], ठीक *Theek* [Theek], डर *Dar* [Dur].

The alternation ladder (do this daily, week 1-4)

Slowly, exaggerating the tongue travel — feel it swing from teeth to curl:

ta - Ta - ta - Ta - ta - Ta · da - Da - da - Da · ata - aTa - ada - aDa · too - Too - doo - Doo

Then words in contrast pairs — read each pair aloud three times:

DENTAL (TEETH)	SAY IT	RETROFLEX (CURL)	SAY IT
दाल <i>daal</i> — lentils	dahl	डाल <i>Daal</i> — branch	Dahl
तन <i>tan</i> — body	tun	टन <i>Tan</i> — ton	Tun
तोता <i>totaa</i> — parrot	toh-tah	टोटा* <i>ToTaa</i> — shortage (colloq.)	Toh-Tah
दो <i>do</i> — two	doh	डो- in डोसा <i>Dosaa</i> — dosa	Doh-sah
नाता <i>naataa</i> — bond, relation	nah-tah	नाटा <i>naaTaa</i> — short (person)	nah-Tah

*Chapter 12 has the full minimal-pair training sets; this is just your daily warm-up.

WATCH OUT

The most common failure isn't picking the wrong family — it's **drifting back to the English ridge** when speaking fast, which makes *every* t/d ambiguous. Slow sentences down for the first month. And one high-stakes example to motivate you: at dinner, दाल *daal* gets you lentils; डाल *Daal* gets you a tree branch. The kitchen will provide daily practice.

DELHI STREET NOTE

Reassurance from the streets of Delhi: nobody expects perfection in week 2. But Delhiites *do* instinctively rate the dental त as the mark of someone who's really learning Hindi (it's the sound English speakers "can't" make). The first time you produce a clean *namaste* with a true dental t, someone in your partner's family will visibly light up. That's the whole game.

WITH YOUR PARTNER

The pointing game, level 2: write त and ट big on two pieces of paper. Partner says single syllables (*ta Ta da Da tee Tee...*) at random; you point. Ten in a row right = they flip the table and you say, they point. Track your streak in the Master Plan tracker.

CHAPTER 4

Aspiration: The Puff That Changes Words

Hold your palm one inch from your lips and say "*pin*." Feel that little explosion? Now say "*spin*." Almost nothing. English makes both kinds of p automatically and treats them as the same letter. Hindi treats them as **different letters that make different words** — and it does this at every single tongue position. That's the fourth column of the grid from Chapter 1, and it's why फ exists next to प and ख next to क.

पल / फल · कल / खल · चल / छल

pal / phal · kal / khal · chal / chhal [pul / phul · kul / khul · chul / chhul]

moment / fruit · yesterday / villain · walk! / deceit

The palm test (your permanent referee)

Every aspirated letter — *kh, chh, Th, th, ph* — should blow out a birthday-candle flame an inch away. Every plain letter — *k, ch, T, t, p* — should barely flutter it. A strip of paper held in front of your lips works too: aspirated = paper jumps; plain = paper twitches. Calibrate daily for two weeks; after that your mouth knows.

Harvesting what English gave you

You already own both sounds — English just hides them by position. Use these harvests:

Plain (no puff)	the p/t/k after s : <i>spin, stop, skip</i> . Say "spin," then say it again without the s — that naked, puff-less "pin" is Hindi प. Same trick: "stop" → त-ish, "skip" → क.
Aspirated (puff)	word-initial English p/t/k: <i>pie, tie, kite</i> — those are naturally puffed. Hindi फ/थ/ख just asks for MORE: puff like you're fogging a mirror.

So the discipline is two-directional: **train your plain letters DOWN** (Americans over-puff everything at the start of words) and **train your aspirates UP** (make the puff theatrical; native speakers' puffs are genuinely strong).

The four-way switchboard, one row at a time

Work each row slowly with the palm test — this is the complete breath system of Hindi:

ROW	1 PLAIN	2 + PUFF	3 VOICED	4 VOICED + BREATHY
soft palate	क <i>ka</i> [kuh]	ख <i>kha</i> [khu]	ग <i>ga</i> [guh]	घ <i>gha</i> [ghuh]

ROW	1 PLAIN	2 + PUFF	3 VOICED	4 VOICED + BREATHY
front dome	च <i>cha</i>	छ <i>chha</i>	ज <i>ja</i>	झ <i>jha</i>
curled back	ट <i>Ta</i>	ठ <i>Tha</i>	ड <i>Da</i>	ढ <i>Dha</i>
teeth	त <i>ta</i>	थ <i>tha</i>	द <i>da</i>	ध <i>dha</i>
lips	प <i>pa</i>	फ <i>pha</i>	ब <i>ba</i>	भ <i>bha</i>

Daily ladder (30 seconds, any row): **ka - kha - ga - gha**, four beats, palm up. The goal is four *clearly different* sounds from one tongue position.

Column 4 — the breathy voiced sounds (the honest hard part)

घ झ ढ ध भ are the one genuinely new skill in this chapter: **voice and breath at the same time**. A plain English g stops the breath; an h has no voice. These want both — a g said while sighing.

Technique 1 — the sighing hum. Hum a lazy "uhhh" and, mid-hum, exhale extra air without stopping the voice — you'll hear a breathy, Marilyn-Monroe texture. Keep that texture running and say *baa* → it becomes *bhaa*. The voice never stops; it just gets air-soaked.

Technique 2 — the compound-word bridge. Say these English pairs fast and smash the boundary: *dog house* → *gh · club house* → *bh · mad hatter* → *dh · hedgehog* → *jh · hot head* (with a curled t) → *Dh-ish*. Crude but effective launchers.

घर · भाई · धन्यवाद · झूठ · ढाई

ghar · bhaaee · dhanyavaad · jhooTh · Dhaaee [ghur · bhah-ee · dhun-yuh-vahd · jhooTh · Dhah-ee]
house · brother · thank you · a lie · two-and-a-half

WATCH OUT

Two classic errors. (1) Saying *bh* as "b-h" — two separate sounds, "ab-haee" — it's ONE sound, a breathy b: [bhah-ee]. (2) Substituting f for फ़: फ़ (*ph*) is a puffed **p** — lips fully close and pop — while फ (f) is the English f. फल *phal* "fruit" with an f is a different (and in some regions unfortunate) word — pop the p.

DELHI STREET NOTE

Delhi reality check: the aspirated column is not optional street garnish — *Theek hai* [Theek heh], *khaanaa*, *bhaaee*, *ghar*, *dhanyavaad* are hour-one words and every one carries a puff or a breathy voice. The single most Delhi sentence you'll say all month — भैया, ठीक है! *bhaiyaa*, *Theek hai!* [bheh-yah Theek heh] — is an aspiration exam all by itself.

WITH YOUR PARTNER

Candle night: light a candle, take turns saying *kal/khal*, *pal/phal*, *taalee/thaalee*, *Deck? no* — *Dol/Dhol*... any pair from Chapter 12's Set 2, watching the flame. The flame is an incorruptible judge and this is legitimately fun. Partner grades your column-4 breathiness on *ghar*, *bhaaee*, *dhoop* — ask them to demonstrate first and put your palm in front of *their* mouth to feel the target.

CHAPTER 5

The Tricky Customers

Beyond the grid live a handful of sounds that each need one honest paragraph of attention. None is as important as Chapters 3–4, but each has a trap.

व — the v/w blend

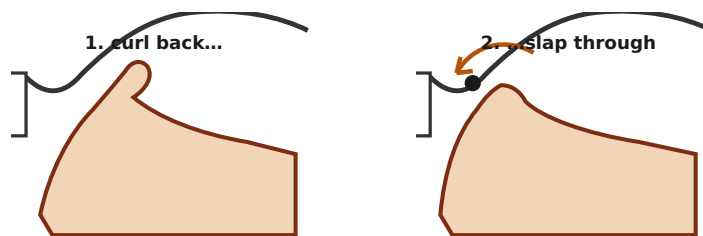
Hindi व is *between* English v and w: round your lips like w, let the upper teeth *barely* graze the lower lip, and keep the friction gentle. A hard English v (teeth digging in, motorboat buzz) sounds foreign; a pure w is closer than a hard v. Honestly, anywhere in the middle is fine — Hindi has no v/w contrast, so nothing can go wrong meaning-wise. वह *voh* [voh], दरवाज़ा *darvaazaa* [dur-vah-zah], स्वागत *svaagat* [svah-gut].

र — the tapped r

Hindi र is a single tap: the tongue tip flicks the ridge once, like the tt in American "butter" said fast. It is never the growly American r of "car" (tongue bunched, no contact). Say "butter" → "budder" → feel that quick d-ish flick — that's र. A short Spanish-style trill is also fine and common. रात *raat* [raht], करना *karnaa* [kur-nah], अरे *arre* [uh-ray].

ड़ / ढ — the retroflex flap (the coolest sound you'll learn)

Here's the secret: **you already make this sound in English.** The dd in "ladder" is a flap — the tongue slaps through the ridge without stopping. Hindi ढ is that exact slap, but starting from the Chapter-3 **curl**: curl the tip up and back like for ढ, then instead of holding contact, *fling* the tip forward so its underside strikes the ridge on the way past. One clean slap, no stop.



The flap: curl like ढ, then fling forward — the underside of the tip strikes the ridge in passing. "Ladder" with a curl.

ड़ never starts a word — it lives in the middles and ends: लड़का *laRkaa* [luhR-kah] boy, थोड़ा *thoRaa* [thoh-Rah] a little, सड़क *saRak* [suh-Ruk] road, पढ़ना *paRhnaa* [puRh-nah] to read/study (ढ = the same flap with breathy release), बड़ा *baRaa* [buh-Rah] big.

WATCH OUT

Don't substitute a plain र: *laRkaa* with a plain r (*larkaa*) is instantly noticeable, and पड़ना *paRnaa* (to fall) vs पढ़ना *paRhnaa* (to study) vs परना? — well, only two of those are words, but your partner "fell a book" jokes write themselves. Curl, then slap.

फ़ vs फ, ज़ vs ज — the Urdu guests

Delhi Hindi is saturated with Persian/Urdu vocabulary, which brought two sounds English already has: **f** (फ़ — फिल्म *film*, फ़ोन *fon*, फ़र्क *farq* "difference") and **z** (ज़: ज़रूर *zaroor* [zuh-roor] "definitely", ज़्यादा *zyaadaa*, मज़ा *mazaa*). The trap runs the other direction: don't let English habits turn every ज into z or every फ into f. जाना is *jaanaa* with a true j; फल is *phal* with a popped, puffed p. The dot under the letter (नुक्ता) is the signal — and yes, Delhiites really do say *z* and *f* clearly, even when they drop the other nukta sounds (क़ ख़ ग़ relax toward plain k/ kh/g in most mouths, and no one will mind if yours do too).

श / ष / स — the s-family

Two working sounds: **sh** (श — and ष, which in modern Hindi is pronounced identically; it survives in spelling only) and **s** (स). English owns both. The only job is reading them correctly: शादी *shaadee* wedding, साल *saal* year, शहर *shehar* [sheh-hur] city, भाषा *bhaashaa* language.

ह — and the vanishing h

ह at the start of words is a normal English h: हाँ *haan*. Between vowels, Delhi speech makes it feather-light or drops it entirely, bending the vowels around it: कहना is [keh-nah] not "ka-ha-na", बहुत is [bo-hut], शहर is [sheh-hur], कहाँ often floats out as [kuh-hah(n)] → [k'hah(n)]. Don't fight it — this is why our phonetic line sometimes disagrees with the spelling; trust the phonetic line, it's transcribing Delhi.

Doubled consonants — park and hold

When a consonant doubles (दिल्ली, अच्छा, बच्चा), you don't say it twice — you **touch, hold one beat, then release once**. English does this across word boundaries: "*bookcase*" (one long k-hold), "*pen-knife*". Practice: पता *pataa* [puh-tah] "address" vs पत्ता *pattaa* [put-tah] "leaf" — in the second, your tongue parks on the t through a full silent beat. दिल्ली [dil-lee]: lean on that l. It's the difference between a city and a mispronunciation.

ङ ञ — the automatic nasals

These two never stand alone in real words — they're the nasal shadows that appear before their row's consonants: the n in रंग *rang* (an "ng"), the n in पंजाब *panjaab* (an "ny-ish n").

English does exactly the same thing automatically (compare the n's in *ink* vs *input*). Read the dot, let your tongue copy the following consonant's position, done. Never force a hard "g" into *rang*.

ल — always the light l

English has two l's: the light l of "*leaf*" (tip forward) and the dark, swallowed l of "*full*" (back bunched). Hindi only uses the light one, tip on the teeth like a dental — even at word ends: दाल *daal* ends bright, not swallowed: [dahl], tip touching teeth on the final l. दिल *dil* [dil] heart — light l, and now you can pronounce both halves of दिलवाले।

WITH YOUR PARTNER

This chapter's partner game is "loanword karaoke": have your partner say ten English-origin words the Delhi way (*fon*, *Taim*, *DaakTar*, *skool*, *glaas*, *boTal*, *kampyooTar*, *peTrol*, *sTeshan*, *hoTal*) and copy their version exactly — curls, vowels and all. It feels like doing an impression; it is, and it's the fastest accent training that exists.

CHAPTER 6

The Invisible Vowel: Schwa & the Vanishing Act

Every Devanagari consonant letter carries a free vowel inside it: क isn't "k," it's "ka" [kuh]. That built-in uh is called the **schwa**, and it explains why the script needs no letter between क and म in कम. So far so good. The plot twist is that spoken Hindi **deletes** many of these built-in vowels — and the spelling never tells you. This chapter is the decoder.

Rule 1 — Word-final schwa is silent. Always.

Written राम is *raam*, not "raama." दिन is *din*. बात is *baat*. If you've heard Sanskrit chanting ("raamaayaNa"), that final -a is exactly what Hindi dropped a few centuries ago. This rule has essentially no exceptions in ordinary words — never voice a final consonant's schwa.

Rule 2 — The middle schwa drops in the __a__ sandwich

When a word runs consonant-a-consonant-a-consonant + vowel, the *second* schwa quietly disappears:

SPELLED (LETTER BY LETTER)	ACTUALLY SAID	WORD
कमरा = ka-ma-raa	kum-rah	<i>kamraa</i> — room
नमकीन = na-ma-keen	num-keen	<i>namkeen</i> — savory snacks
सड़क पर = sa-Ra-k + par	suh-Ruk pur	final schwa silent (Rule 1)
करना = ka-ra-naa	kur-nah	<i>karnaa</i> — to do
आदमी = aa-da-mee	ahd-mee	<i>aadmee</i> — man
जानवर = jaa-na-var	jahn-vur	<i>jaanvar</i> — animal

Contrast the same letters when the sandwich *doesn't* form: नमक "salt" keeps its middle vowel — [nuh-muk] — because dropping it would leave an unsayable word-final cluster (namk). Add a suffix and watch it flip: नमक [nuh-muk] → नमकीन [num-keen]. समझ *samajh* [suh-mujh] → समझा *samjhaa* [sum-jhah]. Same letters, dancing schwa.

NOTE

You do not need to compute this in real time. Two safety nets: (1) every word in this course comes with its phonetic line, schwa-deletion already applied; (2) our Roman spelling also applies it (*karnaa*, never "karanaa"). After a month of reading pairs of lines, your mouth will generalize the pattern without being told — this chapter just makes the magic visible so the spelling never spooks you.

Why this matters for sounding Delhi

Textbook-taught foreigners are instantly recognizable by their fully-voiced schwas: "sa-ma-jha-naa" for *samajhnaa* [suh-mujh-nah], "ka-ha-naa" for *kehnaa* [keh-nah]. Deleting on schedule is half of what makes speech sound native-paced — it's free speed, since you're literally saying less.

The अह special: schwa + h = "eh"

When a schwa sits next to ह, Delhi fuses them into an eh: कहना *kehnaa* [keh-nah], रहना *rehnaa* [reh-nah], शहर *shehar* [sheh-hur], बहन *behen* [beh-hen]. And the superstar irregular: बहुत "very" comes out [bo-hut] in Delhi mouths. Learn these as sounds, not spellings.

Read-aloud practice

Say each, deleting on schedule (answers in the phonetic line — cover it first):

1. बचपन 2. अगरबत्ती 3. मुस्कुराना 4. सब्जीवाला 5. समझदार 6. दिलचस्प

1. *bachpan* · 2. *agarbattee* · 3. *muskuraanaa* · 4. *sabzeevaalaa* · 5. *samajhdaar* · 6. *dilchasp*

[1. buch-pun · 2. uh-gur-but-tee · 3. mus-ku-rah-nah · 4. sub-zee-vah-lah · 5. suh-mujh-dahr · 6. dil-chusp]

1. childhood · 2. incense stick · 3. to smile · 4. vegetable seller · 5. sensible · 6. interesting

CHAPTER 7

Rhythm, Melody & Sounding Delhi

Individual sounds are the letters of an accent; rhythm and melody are its handwriting. This chapter is short on rules and long on ear-training instructions, because prosody is caught more than taught — and you live with a native tuning fork.

Even syllables, gentle stress

English crushes unstressed syllables ("photography" = puh-TOG-ruh-fee). Hindi doesn't. Syllables march out evenly, and "stress" is just a mild lean onto heavy syllables — the ones with long vowels (आ ई ऊ ए ऐ ओ औ) or a doubled consonant. Practice by giving every syllable its full face: *dhanyavaad* is [dhun-yuh-vahd] with three honest syllables, not "DHUN-yvad." When in doubt, flatten your stress rather than exaggerate it — flat sounds more Hindi than punchy.

The melody of questions

Yes/no questions ride a rising tail, exactly like English: चाय पियोगे? *chaay piyoge?* [chah-ay pi-yoh-gay ↗]. Question-word questions (kyaa/kab/kahaan...) fall at the end like statements: तुम कहाँ हो? [tum kuh-hah(n) hoh ↘]. The one special melody to steal: the drawn-out Delhi *achchhaaaa?* [uh-chhaaah ↗] — "ohhh really?" — which does about nine jobs of conversational duty.

Phrases move as blocks

Hindi glues words into little prosodic packets — a noun and its postposition are one breath-unit (*dillee-mein*, *ghar-par*), a verb and its auxiliary another (*jaa-rahaa-hoon*). Pause *between* packets, never inside them. This is why native speech sounds fast: it isn't more sounds per second, it's fewer pauses in the wrong places.

The Delhi sound, itemized

ऐ = eh, औ = aw	है [heh], पैसा [peh-sah], औरत [aw-rut] — never "uh-ee"/"uh-oo." This alone moves you 500 km toward Delhi.
वो and ये	Spoken Delhi says <i>voh</i> and <i>yeh/ye</i> for वह/यह/वे — the spelling-pronunciations "vah/yah" mark a newsreader, not a neighbor.
बहुत = bohot	[bo-hut], often just [boht] at speed. "It's bahut good yaar" is a real Delhi sentence.

Light h	Between vowels h thins out: <i>kahaan</i> → [kuh-hah(n)] with barely a breath on the h.
English everywhere	Numbers, days, tech, feelings — Delhi swaps freely: "Friday ko movie chalein?" Don't fight it; matching the mix is part of the dialect.
Softeners on repeat	<i>jee</i> for respect, <i>na</i> for warmth (<i>chalo na</i>), <i>yaar</i> for friendship, <i>arre</i> to launch a sentence. Delhi conversation is upholstered with these.

DELHI STREET NOTE

What you'll actually hear at family speed: whole auxiliary verbs melting (*kyaa kar rahe ho* → [kyah kur-ray oh]), *naheen* shrinking to [nee/nuh-ee(n)], and everything stitched with *matlab... bas... achchhaa...* Don't panic and don't imitate the melting yet — comprehension first, compression later. Your clear-but-evenly-paced Hindi is exactly right for year one.

Your listening gym (10 minutes/day, no textbook)

Shadowing: take any 15-second clip of Delhi speech (your partner voice-noting a WhatsApp message counts, and is the ideal source), play one sentence, pause, and repeat it *with the melody*, even if you don't know all the words yet. You're photocopying music, not translating. Three sentences a day beats thirty minutes of passive listening. **Eavesdrop practice:** when your partner is on the phone with family, try to catch just the melody — where do sentences rise? where do they land? Which little words repeat? **The weekly line:** each week, pick one line from Book 4's dialogue and get it to "indistinguishable" — partner-certified. Twenty-six perfect lines in six months is a real accent.

WITH YOUR PARTNER

Melody game: partner says the same sentence three ways — statement, yes/no question, surprised exclamation (*tum aa rahe ho. / tum aa rahe ho? / tum aa rahe ho?!)* — in random order; you name which. Then you perform, they guess. If they laugh, that's data too.

CHAPTER 8

The Complete Alphabet, Letter by Letter

This is your reference chapter: every letter of Devanagari, one entry each, in dictionary order. Each entry gives the letter, its Roman spelling, its "Say it" respelling, its IPA value, what it sounds like, what your mouth is doing, and three real words to practice on. You met the mouth mechanics in earlier chapters — here everything sits in one place so you can look any letter up in two seconds. Read it straight through once, then return whenever a letter wobbles.

NOTE

Reminder of the two standing rules from the articulation chapters: **CAPITAL T D N R in Roman = retroflex** (tongue tip curled back; the underside taps the bumpy ridge behind the teeth) and **lowercase t d n = dental** (tongue tip on the back of the upper teeth). An attached **h** (kh, th, bh...) = aspiration, a strong puff of air.

The Vowels (स्वर *svar* [svur])

Vowels are the open, unobstructed sounds — the mouth shapes them with jaw, tongue height, and lips, but nothing blocks the air. Hindi vowels come in short/long pairs and every one is *pure*: no gliding off the end the way English "say" drifts into a y. Hold the shape steady from start to finish.

अ	a · uh · IPA /ə/ Sound: like u in "but" — short, relaxed, central. In your mouth: jaw slightly open, tongue resting flat in the middle, lips neutral; this is the "default" vowel hiding inside every bare consonant. Words: अब <i>ab</i> [ub] now · अगर <i>agar</i> [uh-gur] if · अच्छा <i>achchhaa</i> [uch-chhah] good
आ	aa · ah · IPA /ɑ:/ Sound: like a in "father" — long and open. The doctor's "aah". In your mouth: jaw drops wide, tongue low and flat, lips relaxed; hold it about twice as long as अ. Words: आप <i>aap</i> [ahp] you (polite) · आज <i>aaj</i> [ahj] today · आम <i>aam</i> (m) [ahm] mango

इ	i · i · IPA /ɪ/ Sound: like i in "bit" — short and light. In your mouth: tongue high and forward, jaw nearly closed, lips spread just a little; clip it short. Words: इधर <i>idhar</i> [i-dhur] over here · इतना <i>itnaa</i> [it-nah] this much · इमली <i>imlee</i> (f) [im-lee] tamarind
ई	ee · ee · IPA /i:/ Sound: like ee in "feet" — the long partner of इ. In your mouth: same high-front tongue as इ, lips spread wider, and you hold it; length is the whole difference. Words: ईद <i>eed</i> (f) [eed] Eid · ईंट <i>eenT</i> (f) [ee(n)T] brick · ईमानदार <i>eemaandaar</i> [ee-mahn-dahr] honest
उ	u · u · IPA /ʊ/ Sound: like u in "put" — short, never like the u in "cut". In your mouth: tongue high and pulled back, lips rounded loosely; quick and light. Words: उधर <i>udhar</i> [u-dhur] over there · उठना <i>uThnaa</i> [uTh-nah] to get up · उम्मीद <i>ummeed</i> (f) [um-meed] hope
ऊ	oo · oo · IPA /u:/ Sound: like oo in "boot" — the long partner of उ. In your mouth: same high-back tongue as उ, lips rounded tighter, held long. Words: ऊपर <i>ooper</i> [oo-pur] up, above · ऊन <i>oon</i> (f) [oon] wool · ऊँट <i>oonT</i> (m) [oo(n)T] camel
ऋ	ri · ri · IPA /rɪ/ Sound: an old Sanskrit vowel; in modern Hindi simply "ri" as in "rip". Rare — you'll meet it in a handful of Sanskrit loanwords. In your mouth: a quick tap of the tongue tip plus a short i. Words: ऋतु <i>ritu</i> (f) [ri-tu] season · ऋषि <i>rishi</i> (m) [ri-shi] sage

ए	e · ay · IPA /e:/ Sound: like ay in "say" — but PURE: freeze the first half of the English sound and never let it glide into a y. In your mouth: tongue mid-high and forward, lips slightly spread, jaw steady from start to finish. Words: एक <i>ek</i> [ayk] one · एकदम <i>ekdam</i> [ayk-dum] absolutely · एड़ी <i>eRee</i> (f) [ay-Ree] heel
ऐ	ai · eh · IPA /ɛ:/ Sound: in Delhi, "eh as in bed" — a long open e. (Books that tell you "ai as in aisle" are describing another century.) In your mouth: tongue mid-low and forward, jaw a touch more open than ए; hold it steady. Words: ऐसा <i>aisaa</i> [eh-sah] like this · ऐनक <i>ainak</i> (f) [eh-nuk] eyeglasses · है <i>hai</i> [heh] is (the matra form you'll see constantly)
ओ	o · oh · IPA /o:/ Sound: like o in "go" — but PURE, with no drift toward w at the end. In your mouth: tongue mid-high and back, lips rounded and held still; one clean long vowel. Words: ओर <i>or</i> (f) [ohr] side, direction · ओस <i>os</i> (f) [ohs] dew · ओला <i>olaa</i> (m) [oh-lah] hailstone
औ	au · aw · IPA /ɔ:/ Sound: in Delhi, like aw in "law" — a long open o. Not "ow" as in "cow". In your mouth: tongue mid-low and back, lips lightly rounded, jaw more open than ओ. Words: और <i>aur</i> [awr] and · औरत <i>aurat</i> (f) [aw-rut] woman · औज़ार <i>auzaar</i> (m) [aw-zahr] tool
अं	an · u(n) · IPA /əŋ ~ ẽ/ Sound: not a vowel of its own — the dot (anusvar) is the nasal placeholder: it nasalizes the vowel or stands in for an n/m-type sound before a consonant. Full story in Chapter 9. Words: अंदर <i>andar</i> [un-dur] inside · अंडा <i>anDaa</i> (m) [un-Dah] egg · अंगूर <i>angoor</i> (m) [un-goor] grape

अः	ah · uh-h · IPA /əh/ Sound: the visarg — a rare breathy echo of the vowel, kept alive in a few Sanskrit words and prayers; in everyday speech it's usually silent. Words: दुःख <i>dukh</i> (m) [dukh] sorrow (the :is silent here in normal speech) · नमः <i>namah</i> [nuh-muh-h] salutation (in prayers)
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The Velar Row: क ख ग घ ङ (back of the tongue)

All five velars are made at the same spot: the **back of the tongue rises to touch the soft palate** — exactly where English k and g live. What changes across the row is only voice and breath: voiceless plain, voiceless with the puff, voiced plain, voiced with the sigh, and the nasal. Keep your palm up in front of your mouth for the whole row.

क	ka · kuh · IPA /kə/ Sound: like k in "skip" — NO puff of air. In your mouth: back of the tongue rises to touch the soft palate; release cleanly with zero breath. Words: कल <i>kal</i> [kul] yesterday/tomorrow · कमरा <i>kamraa</i> (m) [kum-rah] room · किताब <i>kitaab</i> (f) [ki-tahb] book
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ख	kha · khuh · IPA /kʰə/ Sound: like k in "kit", exaggerated — with a strong puff of air (palm test!). In your mouth: same tongue position as क, add the puff; the palm should feel a clear burst. Words: खाना <i>khaanaa</i> (m) [khah-nah] food; to eat · खिड़की <i>khiRkee</i> (f) [khiR-kee] window · खुश <i>khush</i> [khush] happy
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ग	ga · guh · IPA /gə/ Sound: like g in "go" — voiced, no puff of air. In your mouth: same spot as क but the vocal cords hum from the start; release clean. Words: गाना <i>gaanaa</i> (m) [gah-nah] song; to sing · गाड़ी <i>gaaRee</i> (f) [gah-Ree] car, vehicle · गली <i>galee</i> (f) [guh-lee] lane
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घ	gha · ghuh · IPA /gʱə/ Sound: a g that comes out voiced with breathy, sighing release — "g-huh" said as one sound. In your mouth: same tongue position as ग; keep the voice humming while breath floods out on the release. Words: घर <i>ghar</i> (m) [ghur] house, home · घड़ी <i>ghaRee</i> (f) [ghuh-Ree] watch, clock · घंटा <i>ghanTaa</i> (m) [ghun-Tah] hour; bell
ङ	nga · ng · IPA /ŋ/ Sound: the ng of "sing". It never stands alone in a Hindi word — you'll only ever meet it hiding inside words as the n before a k or g sound, almost always written with the anusvar dot, as in अंक. Words: अंक <i>ank</i> (m) [unk] digit, mark · पंखा <i>pankhaa</i> (m) [pun-khah] fan

The Palatal Row: च छ ज झ ञ (middle of the tongue)

These five are made where English ch and j live: the **middle of the tongue presses up against the hard palate** just behind the ridge, and the release gives that ch/j quality. Hindi's versions are a little flatter and tighter than English — no lip rounding, no drawl. Same drill as the velars: plain, puff, voiced, sigh, nasal.

च	cha · chuh · IPA /t͡ʃə/ Sound: like ch in "cheese" but tighter — no puff of air (English ch leaks a small puff; pinch it off). In your mouth: middle of the tongue flat against the hard palate; release cleanly with zero breath. Words: चाय <i>chaay</i> (f) [chah-ay] tea · चलो <i>chalo</i> [chuh-loh] let's go · चम्मच <i>chammach</i> (m) [chum-much] spoon
छ	chha · chhuh · IPA /t͡ʃʰə/ Sound: a ch with a strong puff of air (palm test!). In your mouth: same tongue position as च, add the puff — a real burst, bigger than any English ch. Words: छत <i>chhat</i> (f) [chhut] roof · छोटा <i>chhoTaa</i> [chhoh-Tah] small · छुट्टी <i>chhuTTee</i> (f) [chhuT-Tee] holiday, day off

ज	ja · juh · IPA /dʒə/ Sound: like j in "jug" — voiced, no puff of air. In your mouth: same spot as च with the vocal cords humming. Words: जाना <i>jaanaa</i> [jah-nah] to go · जेब <i>jeb</i> (f) [jayb] pocket · जल्दी <i>jaldee</i> (f) [jul-dee] hurry; quickly
झ	jha · jhuh · IPA /dʒʰə/ Sound: a j that is voiced with breathy, sighing release — "j-huh" as one sound. In your mouth: same tongue position as ज; keep the hum going and let breath pour out as you release. Words: झूठ <i>jhooTh</i> (m) [jhooTh] lie · झील <i>jheel</i> (f) [jheel] lake · झगड़ा <i>jhagRaa</i> (m) [jhug-Rah] quarrel
ञ	nya · ny · IPA /ɲ/ Sound: the ny of "canyon". Like ङ, it never stands alone in modern Hindi — it lives only as the nasal before ch/j sounds, normally written with the anusvar dot. Words: पंजाब <i>panjaab</i> (m) [pun-jahb] Punjab · चंचल <i>chanchal</i> [chun-chul] restless, playful

The Retroflex Row: ट ठ ड ढ ण + the Flaps ढ़ ढ़ (tongue curled back)

Now the sounds that make Hindi sound like Hindi. For all of these the **tongue tip is curled back; the underside taps the bumpy ridge behind the teeth**. English t and d sit close to this territory, which is exactly why Indians hear an American t as ट — your job is to make the curl deliberate here and keep it OUT of the dental row that follows. The two dotted letters ढ़ ढ़ are flaps: the curled tongue doesn't hold its contact but flicks forward, striking the ridge on the way.

ट	Ta · Tuh · IPA /t̪ə/ Sound: close to the t in "stop", but darker and harder — no puff of air. In your mouth: tongue tip curled back; the underside taps the bumpy ridge behind the teeth; release with zero breath. Words: टमाटर <i>TamaaTar</i> (m) [Tuh-mah-Tur] tomato · टोपी <i>Topee</i> (f) [Toh-pee] cap · टाइम <i>Taim</i> (m) [Tah-im] time (the everyday loanword)
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ठ	Tha · Thuh · IPA /tʰə/ Sound: the curled T with a strong puff of air (palm test!). Never the th of "think" — English th does not exist in Hindi. In your mouth: same tongue position as ट, add the puff. Words: ठीक <i>Theek</i> [Theek] fine, okay · ठंड <i>ThanD</i> (f) [ThunD] cold (weather) · ठग <i>Thag</i> (m) [Thug] con man (yes — English "thug" is this word)
ड	Da · Duh · IPA /d̪ə/ Sound: close to the d in "dog" but darker — voiced, no puff of air. In your mouth: tongue tip curled back; the underside taps the bumpy ridge behind the teeth; vocal cords humming. Words: डर <i>Dar</i> (m) [Dur] fear · डाल <i>Daal</i> (f) [Dahl] branch · डिब्बा <i>Dibbaa</i> (m) [Dib-bah] box, container
ढ	Dha · Dhuh · IPA /d̪ʱə/ Sound: the curled D, voiced with breathy, sighing release. In your mouth: same tongue position as ड; hum plus a flood of breath on release. Words: ढाई <i>Dhaaee</i> [Dhah-ee] two and a half · ढक्कन <i>Dhakkan</i> (m) [Dhuk-kun] lid · ढाबा <i>Dhaabaa</i> (m) [Dhah-bah] roadside eatery
ण	Na · Nuh · IPA /ɳə/ Sound: an n said with the retroflex curl. It appears mostly in Sanskrit loanwords; many Delhi speakers relax it toward a plain n, and no one will blink if you do too. In your mouth: tongue tip curled back; the underside taps the bumpy ridge behind the teeth while air flows through the nose. Words: कारण <i>kaaraN</i> (m) [kah-ruN] reason · प्रणाम <i>praNaam</i> (m) [pruh-Nahm] respectful greeting · गुण <i>guN</i> (m) [guN] quality, virtue
र	Ra · Ruh · IPA /ɽə/ Sound: the famous retroflex flap — a d and an r colliding. Never starts a word. In your mouth: tongue curls back as for ड, then FLICKS forward, striking the ridge on the way — one fast brush, no holding. Words: लड़का <i>laRkaa</i> (m) [luhR-kah] boy · सड़क <i>saRak</i> (f) [suh-Ruk] road · थोड़ा <i>thoRaa</i> [thoh-Rah] a little

ॢ	Rha · Rhuh · IPA /ɽʱə/ Sound: the same flap as ङ, voiced with breathy, sighing release. Also never starts a word. In your mouth: tongue curls back then FLICKS forward, striking on the way — with a sigh of breath riding the flick. Words: पढ़ना <i>paRhnaa</i> [puRh-nah] to read, to study · बढ़िया <i>baRhiyaa</i> [buh-Rhi-yah] excellent, first-rate · सीढ़ी <i>seeRhee</i> (f) [see-Rhee] staircase, ladder
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The Dental Row: त थ द ध न (tongue on the teeth)

Here the **tongue tip is pressed against the back of the upper teeth**, like a Spanish or French t — noticeably farther forward than any English t or d. This row is the mirror-image trap of the retroflex row: an English speaker's automatic t/d lands in the middle and gets heard as retroflex, so for these five you must consciously touch the teeth. Feel actual tooth enamel on every one.

त	ta · tuh · IPA /t̪ə/ Sound: like the t of Spanish "taco" — flat, forward, no puff of air. In your mouth: tongue tip on the back of the upper teeth; release cleanly with zero breath. Words: तीन <i>teen</i> [teen] three · तुम <i>tum</i> [tum] you (informal) · तारा <i>taaraa</i> (m) [tah-rah] star
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थ	tha · thuh · IPA /t̪ʰə/ Sound: the dental t with a strong puff of air (palm test!). NOT the th of "think" — the tongue touches the back of the teeth, it never pokes between them. In your mouth: same tongue position as त, add the puff. Words: थाली <i>thaalee</i> (f) [thah-lee] platter, thali · थकान <i>thakaan</i> (f) [thuh-kahn] tiredness · हाथ <i>haath</i> (m) [hahth] hand
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द	da · duh · IPA /d̪ə/ Sound: like the d of Spanish "dos" — voiced, forward, no puff of air. In your mouth: tongue tip on the back of the upper teeth; vocal cords humming. Words: दिन <i>din</i> (m) [din] day · दाल <i>daal</i> (f) [dahl] lentils · दरवाज़ा <i>darvaazaa</i> (m) [dur-vah-zah] door
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ध	dha · dhuh · IPA /d̪ʱə/ Sound: the dental d, voiced with breathy, sighing release. In your mouth: same tongue position as द; keep the hum and let the breath sigh out on release. Words: धन्यवाद <i>dhanyavaad</i> (m) [dhun-yuh-vahd] thank you (formal) · धूप <i>dhoop</i> (f) [dhoop] sunshine · दूध <i>doodh</i> (m) [doodh] milk
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न	na · nuh · IPA /n̪ə/ Sound: an n said forward — slightly "brighter" than English n. In your mouth: tongue tip on the back of the upper teeth while air flows through the nose. Words: नमस्ते <i>namaste</i> [nuh-muhs-tay] hello, namaste · नाम <i>naam</i> (m) [nahm] name · नया <i>nayaa</i> [nuh-yah] new
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The Labial Row: प फ ब भ म (both lips)

Easiest row in the book: **both lips press together and release**, exactly like English p, b, m. The only work is the breath discipline — keeping प bone-dry, giving फ a real burst, and letting भ sigh. Palm up again.

प	pa · puh · IPA /pə/ Sound: like p in "spin" — no puff of air. In your mouth: lips together, release cleanly with zero breath; the palm feels nothing. Words: पानी <i>paanee</i> (m) [pah-nee] water · पल <i>pal</i> (m) [pul] moment · पैसा <i>paisaa</i> (m) [peh-sah] money; paisa
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फ	pha · phuh · IPA /pʰə/ Sound: a p with a strong puff of air (palm test!). It is NOT an f — the lips pop apart; the teeth never touch the lip. In your mouth: same lip position as प, add the puff. Words: फल <i>phal</i> (m) [phul] fruit · फूल <i>phool</i> (m) [phool] flower · फिर <i>phir</i> [phir] then, again
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ब	ba · buh · IPA /bə/ Sound: like b in "big" — voiced, no puff of air. In your mouth: lips together, vocal cords humming, clean release. Words: बस <i>bas</i> (f) [bus] bus; enough! · बात <i>baat</i> (f) [baht] talk, matter · बड़ा <i>baRaa</i> [buh-Rah] big
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भ	bha · bhuh · IPA /bʱə/ Sound: a b that is voiced with breathy, sighing release — "b-huh" as one sound. In your mouth: same lip position as ब; keep the hum and let breath pour out as the lips open. Words: भाई <i>bhaaee</i> (m) [bhah-ee] brother · भारत <i>bhaarat</i> (m) [bhah-rut] India · भूख <i>bhookh</i> (f) [bhookh] hunger
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म	ma · muh · IPA /mə/ Sound: exactly English m. In your mouth: lips together, air through the nose, voice on. Words: माँ <i>maan</i> (f) [mah(n)] mom · मैं <i>main</i> [meh(n)] I · मकान <i>makaan</i> (m) [muh-kahn] house (building)
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Semivowels & Liquids: य र ल व (glides and flows)

These four sit halfway between consonant and vowel — the air keeps moving; nothing fully closes. Three of them are friendly; only व needs real attention, because it is neither the English v nor the English w but a soft sound in between.

य	ya · yuh · IPA /jə/ Sound: like y in "yes". In your mouth: middle of the tongue rises toward the palate without touching; a smooth glide. Words: यह <i>yeh</i> [yeh] this (spelled ya-ha, said yeh!) · यहाँ <i>yahaan</i> [yuh-hah(n)] here · यार <i>yaar</i> (m) [yahr] buddy, dude
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र	ra · ruh · IPA /rə/ Sound: a quick tapped r, like the r in Spanish "pero" or the tt in American "butter". Never the curled-back American r. In your mouth: tongue tip flicks once against the ridge just behind the upper teeth — one light tap, tip pointing up, not curled. Words: रात <i>raat</i> (f) [raht] night · रोटी <i>roTee</i> (f) [roh-Tee] flatbread, roti · रहना <i>rehnaa</i> [reh-nah] to live, to stay
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ल	la · luh · IPA /l̪ə/ Sound: a light, clear l — like the l in "leaf", never the dark l of "full". In your mouth: tongue tip on the back of the upper teeth; air flows around the sides. Words: लाल <i>laal</i> [lahl] red · लड़की <i>laRkee</i> (f) [luhR-kee] girl · लेकिन <i>lekin</i> [lay-kin] but
व	va · vuh · IPA /və/ Sound: between v and w. Start saying "w", then let the upper teeth drift toward the lower lip — but stop before they bite. In your mouth: upper teeth LIGHTLY near the lower lip, no hard friction; lips softly rounded. Both an English v and an English w will be understood — the real sound floats between them. Words: वह <i>voh</i> [voh] that; he/she (spelled va-ha, said voh!) · वहाँ <i>vahaan</i> [vuh-hah(n)] there · वापस <i>vaapas</i> [vah-pus] back (return)

Sibilants & h: श ष स ह (the hissers and the breath)

Three s-type letters plus the breathy h. The tongue makes a narrow channel and the air hisses through it — farther back for श, right behind the teeth for स. Good news: modern Hindi has collapsed श and ष into one sound, so you only have two hisses to learn.

श	sha · shuh · IPA /ʃə/ Sound: like sh in "ship". In your mouth: blade of the tongue raised toward the front of the palate, lips very slightly pushed out; a broad hiss. Words: शाम <i>shaam</i> (f) [shahm] evening · शहर <i>shehar</i> (m) [sheh-hur] city · शादी <i>shaadee</i> (f) [shah-dee] wedding
ष	Sha · shuh · IPA /ʃə/ Sound: in modern Hindi pronounced exactly the same as श — say "sh" and you're done. Historically it was a retroflex sh; today it survives only in spelling, in Sanskrit loanwords. Words: भाषा <i>bhaaShaa</i> (f) [bhah-shah] language · विशेष <i>visheSh</i> [vi-shaysh] special

स	sa · suh · IPA /sə/ Sound: like s in "sun". In your mouth: tongue tip close behind the upper teeth, thin jet of air — a sharp, forward hiss. Words: सब <i>sab</i> [sub] all, everyone · साल <i>saal</i> (m) [sahl] year · सस्ता <i>sastaa</i> [sus-tah] cheap
ह	ha · huh · IPA /hə/ Sound: like h in "ahead" — a soft, voiced breath, warmer than the h in "hat". In your mouth: nothing moves; the breath itself carries a light hum through an open throat. Words: हाँ <i>haan</i> [hah(n)] yes · हवा <i>havaa</i> (f) [huh-vah] air, wind · होना <i>hona</i> [hoh-nah] to be

The Dotted Letters: क़ ख़ ग़ ज़ फ़ (nukta / Urdu sounds)

A dot under a letter (the **nukta**) marks a sound borrowed through Persian, Arabic, and English — the Urdu side of Delhi's tongue. Two of these are non-negotiable: **ज़ z and फ़ f are essential and everywhere** — ज़रूर *zaroor* [zuh-roor], फ़िल्म *film* [film]. The other three (क़ ख़ ग़) are throat sounds that most Delhi speakers relax to plain k/kh/g in everyday talk; learn to recognize them and don't stress about producing them.

क़	qa · kuh · IPA /qə/ Sound: a k made deeper in the throat (Arabic qaf). In Delhi speech it usually relaxes to a plain k — say k and you're fine. In your mouth: the very back of the tongue touches the uvula, farther back than क. Words: क़रीब <i>qareeb</i> [kuh-reeb] near; approximately · क़ानून <i>qaanoon</i> (m) [kah-noon] law
ख़	kha · khuh · IPA /xə/ Sound: the rasping ch of German "Bach" or Scottish "loch". Delhi speakers often soften it to a plain ख — either is fine. In your mouth: back of the tongue close to the soft palate without sealing; air scrapes through. Words: ख़त <i>khat</i> (m) [khut] letter (mail) · ख़बर <i>khavar</i> (f) [khuh-bur] news

ग़	ga · guh · IPA /ɣə/ Sound: a gargled g — the voiced twin of ख़, like a French r said with g-color. In Delhi it usually relaxes to plain g. In your mouth: same near-closure as ख़ with the voice switched on. Words: ग़लत <i>galat</i> [guh-lut] wrong · ग़रीब <i>gareeb</i> [guh-reeb] poor
ज़	za · zuh · IPA /zə/ Sound: like z in "zoo". Essential — Delhi speech is full of it, and swapping it for j (jaroor for zaroor) is a heavily-mocked mistake. In your mouth: exactly like स with the voice switched on. Words: ज़रूर <i>zaroor</i> [zuh-roor] definitely · ज़्यादा <i>zyaadaa</i> [zyah-dah] more · मेज़ <i>mez</i> (f) [mayz] table
फ़	fa · fuh · IPA /fə/ Sound: like f in "fun". Essential — फ़ोन, फ़िल्म, and half the loanwords in Delhi carry it. In your mouth: upper teeth on the lower lip with real friction — unlike व, here the contact genuinely buzzes. Words: फ़ोन <i>fon</i> (m) [fohn] phone · फ़िल्म <i>film</i> (f) [film] film, movie · फ़र्क <i>farq</i> (m) [furk] difference

DELHI STREET NOTE

Street reality check: on a Delhi shop board you'll see the nukta dropped half the time — जरूर for ज़रूर, फिल्म for फ़िल्म. The dot may vanish in writing, but the z and f sounds do NOT vanish in speech. Read the word, not just the dot: if it's a Persian/Arabic/English loan, it keeps its z and f.

NOTE

That's the full inventory: 13 vowel entries, 33 core consonants, 2 flaps, and 5 dotted letters. Everything else you will ever read in Hindi is these letters plus the vowel signs and stacking rules of Chapter 9.

CHAPTER 9

Matras, Conjuncts & How Words Assemble

Chapter 8 gave you the letters; this chapter gives you the assembly manual. Devanagari is not really an alphabet of separate letters standing in a row — it's a system of consonant frames that carry vowel signs, stack into clusters, and hang from that headline bar. Master the four mechanisms here — the built-in *a*, the matras, the vowel-killer, and the conjuncts — and you can read any word in this course.

1. The Inherent 'a': Every Bare Consonant Comes Pre-Loaded

A bare consonant letter is never just a consonant. क is not "k" — it is **ka** [kuh]: the consonant plus a built-in short *a*. Every consonant letter in the script works this way. So a word can be spelled with no vowel signs at all and still be full of vowels:

नमक = न + म + क

namak [nuh-muk]

salt (m) — three bare consonants, and the word comes out na-ma-k.

समझ = स + म + झ

samajh [suh-mujh]

understanding (f) — again, the a's are free.

NOTE

You'll notice the built-in *a* quietly disappears in certain spots — above all at the end of a word: नमक is *namak* [nuh-muk], never "namaka". It also drops inside many longer words (कमरा is *kamraa* [kum-rah], not "ka-ma-raa"). Don't memorize rules for this yet — the Roman column in this course always writes what is actually said, so just copy it. Your ear will absorb the pattern within weeks.

2. Matras: The Vowel Signs

To put any other vowel on a consonant, you don't write the full vowel letter — you attach a small sign, a **matra** (मात्रा *maatras* (f) [maht-rah]), to the consonant frame. The full vowel letters from Chapter 8 are used only when the vowel starts a word or syllable of its own (आम, एक). Here is क wearing every matra:

FORM	VOWEL ADDED	ROMAN	SAY IT	WHERE THE SIGN SITS
क	— (inherent a)	<i>ka</i>	kuh	nothing to add

FORM	VOWEL ADDED	ROMAN	SAY IT	WHERE THE SIGN SITS
का	आ aa	<i>kaa</i>	kah	vertical stroke after
कि	इ i	<i>ki</i>	ki	hook BEFORE the letter (!)
की	ई ee	<i>kee</i>	kee	hook after
कु	उ u	<i>ku</i>	ku	small hook below
कू	ऊ oo	<i>koo</i>	koo	bigger hook below
कृ	ऋ ri	<i>kri</i>	kri	little curl below
के	ए e	<i>ke</i>	kay	slash above the bar
कै	ऐ ai	<i>kai</i>	keh	double slash above
को	ओ o	<i>ko</i>	koh	stroke after + slash above
कौ	औ au	<i>kau</i>	kaw	stroke after + double slash
कं	ं anusvar (nasal)	<i>kan</i>	ku(n)	dot above
कः	ः visarg	<i>kah</i>	kuh-h	two dots after (rare)
काँ	ँ aa + candrabindu	<i>kaan</i>	kah(n)	moon-dot above

WATCH OUT

The #1 reading surprise in all of Devanagari: the इ-matra is written to the LEFT of its consonant but pronounced AFTER it. कि is **ki** — never "ik". The hook you see first is a flag announcing "an i-vowel follows this letter." So किताब reads *kitaab* [ki-tahb], दिन reads *din* [din], फिर reads *phir* [phir]. Your eye must learn to jump one letter ahead and come back — after a week of reading it becomes automatic.

3. The Same Matras on Different Letters

Matras keep their shape no matter which consonant they ride — learn them once on क and you can read them on everything. Scan these rows out loud:

+ (A)	+AA	+I	+EE	+U	+OO	+E	+AI	+O	+AU
क	का	कि	की	कु	कू	के	कै	को	कौ
ब	बा	बि	बी	बु	बू	बे	बै	बो	बौ

+ (A)	+AA	+I	+EE	+U	+OO	+E	+AI	+O	+AU
म	मा	मि	मी	मु	मू	मे	मै	मो	मौ
स	सा	सि	सी	सु	सू	से	सै	सो	सौ
र	रा	रि	री	रु	रू	रे	रै	रो	रौ

One famous exception, bolded above: on र the u-hooks refuse to hang underneath. Instead they swing out from the letter's waist: रु = **ru** [ru] and रू = **roo** [roo]. You will meet these constantly:

हिन्दी	ROMAN	SAY IT	MEANING
रुपया	<i>rupayaa</i> (m)	ru-puh-yah	rupee
रूमाल	<i>roomaal</i> (m)	roo-mahl	handkerchief
ज़रूर	<i>zaroor</i>	zuh-roor	definitely
शुरू	<i>shuroo</i> (m)	shu-roo	start, beginning

4. The Vowel-Killer: Halant

What if you need a consonant with NO vowel at all — a bare k, s, t? A small diagonal stroke under the letter, the **halant** (also called *viraam*), kills the inherent a:

क = ka, लेकिन क् = k

ka ... k [kuh ... k]

the stroke under the letter deletes its built-in vowel. (*lekin* = but)

You will rarely see the halant written out in everyday words, because when a vowel-less consonant runs into the next consonant, the script does something more elegant: it fuses the two letters into a single stacked shape. That is the conjunct — the last big mechanism, and the reason दिल्ली is written with two letters where you might expect three.

5. Conjuncts: When Consonants Stack

Two consonants with no vowel between them fuse into one glyph: usually the first letter **drops its vertical stem** and welds onto the second. So स + क → स्क, क + य → क्य, च + च → च्च. A few pairs fuse into special shapes you simply memorize (क्षत्रज्ञश्च). Below is your reference wall: the conjuncts that cover nearly everything you'll read in this course, each with one real word. Don't memorize the tables — read the example words aloud, and let the shapes soak in.

Doubled letters (gemimates — hold the consonant longer)

CONJUNCT	BUILT FROM	EXAMPLE	MEANING
क्क	क + क	पक्का <i>pakkaa</i> [puk-kah]	firm, sure, for-certain
च्च	च + च	बच्चा <i>bachchaa</i> (m) [buch-chah]	child
ज्ज	ज + ज	सज्जन <i>sajjan</i> (m) [suj-jun]	gentleman
त्त	त + त	पत्ता <i>pattaa</i> (m) [put-tah]	leaf
द्ध	द + द	ज़िद्दी <i>ziddee</i> [zid-dee]	stubborn
द्ध	द + ध	शुद्ध <i>shuddh</i> [shud-dh]	pure
न्न	न + न	सुनना <i>sunnaa</i> [sun-nah]	to listen, to hear
प्प	प + प	गप्पें <i>gappen</i> (f) [gup-pay(n)]	gossip, idle chat (<i>gappen maarnaa</i> = to shoot the breeze)
ब्ब	ब + ब	डिब्बा <i>Dibbaa</i> (m) [Dib-bah]	box; train car
म्म	म + म	चम्मच <i>chammach</i> (m) [chum-much]	spoon
ल्ल	ल + ल	दिल्ली <i>dillee</i> (f) [dil-lee]	Delhi
स्स	स + स	रस्सी <i>rassee</i> (f) [rus-see]	rope
ट्ट	ट + ट	छुट्टी <i>chhuTTee</i> (f) [chhuT-Tee]	holiday, day off
ठ्ठ	ट + ठ	चिट्ठी <i>chiTThee</i> (f) [chiT-Thee]	letter, note
ड्ड	ड + ड	लड्डू <i>laDDoo</i> (m) [luD-Doo]	laddu (the sweet)

Notice how the retroflex letters stack vertically (ट्ट, ड्ड) instead of losing a stem — they have no vertical stem to lose. Say every geminate as a held, doubled consonant: put-tah, not pu-tah. Chapter 12 drills this.

Clusters with y and v

CONJUNCT	BUILT FROM	EXAMPLE	MEANING
क्य	क + य	क्या <i>kyaa</i> [kyah]	what
प्य	प + य	प्यार <i>pyaar</i> (m) [pyahr]	love
स्व	स + व	स्वागत <i>svaagat</i> (m) [svah-gut]	welcome

Clusters with s (the "school-station" set)

CONJUNCT	BUILT FROM	EXAMPLE	MEANING
स्त	स + त	रास्ता <i>raastaa</i> (m) [rahs-tah]	road, way
स्त्र	स + त + र	स्त्री <i>stree</i> (f) [stree]	woman (formal — you'll see it on signs)
स्क	स + क	स्कूल <i>skool</i> (m) [skool]	school
स्ट	स + ट	स्टेशन <i>sTeshan</i> (m) [sTay-shun]	station
स्प	स + प	अस्पताल <i>aspataal</i> (m) [us-puh-tahl]	hospital
स्थ	स + थ	स्थान <i>sthaan</i> (m) [sthahn]	place (formal — metro announcements)

Clusters with h

CONJUNCT	BUILT FROM	EXAMPLE	MEANING
न्ह	न + ह	उन्हें <i>unhen</i> [un-hay(n)]	to them
म्ह	म + ह	तुम्हारा <i>tumhaaraa</i> [tum-hah-rah]	your (informal)
ल्ह	ल + ह	कुल्हड़ <i>kulhaR</i> (m) [kul-huR]	clay cup (for chai)

Nasal + consonant

CONJUNCT	BUILT FROM	EXAMPLE	MEANING
न्द	न + द	बन्द <i>band</i> [bund]	closed (also written बंद)

CONJUNCT	BUILT FROM	EXAMPLE	MEANING
न्द्र	न + द + र	चन्द्रमा <i>chandrmaa</i> (m) [chun-druh-mah]	moon (formal; everyday word is चाँद <i>chaand</i> [chah(n)d])
न्त	न + त	शान्त <i>shaant</i> [shahnt]	calm, quiet (also written शांत)
म्ब	म + ब	लम्बा <i>lambaa</i> [lum-bah]	long, tall (also written लंबा)
म्प	म + प	कम्पनी <i>kampanee</i> (f) [kum-puh-nee]	company (also written कंपनी)
ंक	dot for ड + क	बैंक <i>baink</i> (m) [beh(n)k]	bank
ंच	dot for ज + च	खींचना <i>kheenchnaa</i> [khee(n)ch-nah]	to pull (खींचो on a door = PULL)

The special shapes: क्षत्रज्ञश्र

Four fusions changed so much in the welding that you just learn them as new letters:

CONJUNCT	BUILT FROM	EXAMPLE	MEANING
क्ष	क + ष → "ksh"	शिक्षा <i>shikshaa</i> (f) [shik-shah]	education
त्र	त + र → "tr"	यात्रा <i>yaatraa</i> (f) [yaht-rah]	journey (metro: "aapkee yaatraa mangalmay ho")
ज्ञ	ज + ज → said "gy"!	ज्ञान <i>gyaan</i> (m) [gyahn]	knowledge (never "jn" — modern Hindi says gy)
श्र	श + र → "shr"	श्री <i>shree</i> [shree]	Shri / Mr. (on every wedding card)

DELHI STREET NOTE

Spot-the-conjunct is a great Delhi street game: बच्चा *bachchaa* [buch-chah] child · सच्चा *sachchaa* [such-chah] truthful · बिल्ली *billee* [bil-lee] cat · क्रिकेट *krikeT* [kri-kayT] cricket · हिन्दी *hindie* [hin-dee] Hindi · ज़िन्दगी *zindagee* [zin-duh-gee] life (f). Every auto, every poster, every serial title — conjuncts everywhere. Read them out loud as you ride.

6. The र Special Cases: One Letter, Three Disguises

The letter र refuses to join clusters the normal way. It has costumes for both roles — and one of them breaks the left-to-right rule of the script entirely.

र as the SECOND member: a slash or a knee

When another consonant is followed by र, the र shrinks to a small diagonal slash tucked under that consonant:

CLUSTER	BUILT FROM	EXAMPLE	MEANING
क्र	क + र = kra	क्रिकेट <i>krikeT</i> (m) [kri-kayT]	cricket
प्र	प + र = pra	प्रेम <i>prem</i> (m) [praym]	love (the formal, poetic word)
ग्र	ग + र = gra	ग्राहक <i>graahak</i> (m) [grah-huk]	customer

On the stemless retroflex letters the slash can't attach, so र becomes a little bent "knee" hanging below:

CLUSTER	BUILT FROM	EXAMPLE	MEANING
ट्र	ट + र = Tra	ट्रेन <i>Tren</i> (f) [Trayn]	train
ड्र	ड + र = Dra	ड्राइवर <i>Draaivar</i> (m) [Drah-i-vur]	driver

र as the FIRST member: the reph, written ABOVE — and out of order

When र comes first in a cluster (r + consonant), it leaves the line of writing altogether. It becomes a small curl called the **reph**, perched on top of the FOLLOWING letter. Read it before the letter it sits on: **the r sound comes BEFORE the letter it sits on.**

WORD	READS AS	ROMAN	SAY IT	MEANING
कर्म	क + र्म = ka-r-ma	<i>karm</i> (m)	kur̥m	deed; karma
धर्म	ध + र्म	<i>dharm</i> (m)	dhur̥m	religion; duty
शर्म	श + र्म	<i>sharm</i> (f)	shur̥m	shyness, shame
गर्म	ग + र्म	<i>garm</i>	gur̥m	hot
मिर्च	मि + र्च	<i>mirch</i> (f)	mir̥ch	chili
सिर्फ़	सि + र्फ़	<i>sirf</i>	sir̥f	only, just

WATCH OUT

Beginners see गर्म and read "gamr" or "garam-with-something". Work right to left through the stack: the reph on म means the r is pronounced first — *garm* [gurm]. And note the double illusion in मिर्च: the i-matra is written left but sounds after म, and the reph is written on च but sounds before it. Written order मि-र्च, spoken order m-i-r-ch [mirch]. This one word is the whole chapter in miniature.

7. Spelling Conventions: Anusvar[˙] and Candrabindu^{◌ँ}

Hindi has two nasal marks, and Delhi print uses them loosely — so learn what's behind them.

The anusvar dot standing in for a nasal conjunct. Before another consonant, the dot is simply shorthand for the nasal of that consonant's row (n before dentals, m before labials, ng before k/g, and so on). That means many words have two equally correct spellings — full conjunct or dot:

CONJUNCT SPELLING	DOT SPELLING	ROMAN	SAY IT	MEANING
हिन्दी	हिंदी	<i>hindēe</i> (f)	hin-dee	Hindi (this course writes हिन्दी)
बन्द	बंद	<i>band</i>	bund	closed
लम्बा	लंबा	<i>lambaa</i>	lum-bah	long, tall — before a labial the dot reads as m
ज़िन्दगी	ज़िंदगी	<i>zindagee</i> (f)	zin-duh-gee	life

Same word, same sound, two outfits — signboards mix them freely, so recognize both.

The candrabindu (moon-dot) for pure nasal vowels. ◌ँ doesn't stand for any n or m consonant — it sends the vowel itself through the nose, French-style. It lives on the most homely words in the language:

हिन्दी	ROMAN	SAY IT	MEANING
हाँ	<i>haan</i>	hah(n)	yes
कहाँ	<i>kahaan</i>	kuh-hah(n)	where
आँख	<i>aankh</i> (f)	ah(n)kh	eye
माँ	<i>maan</i> (f)	mah(n)	mom

NOTE

When the space above a letter is already occupied by a matra (ँ, ै, ...), the moon has no room, so only the dot is printed even for a pure nasal vowel: नहीं *naheen* [nuh-hee(n)] no, मैं *main* [meh(n)] I, में *mein* [may(n)] in. Keep that last pair apart: मैं [meh(n)] vs में [may(n)].

8. Devanagari Digits & the Full Stop

Modern Delhi writes numbers with Western digits almost everywhere, but the Devanagari set still appears on older signs, temple boards, and official Hindi documents. Recognize them:

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
०	१	२	३	४	५	६	७	८	९

Watch for the tricksters: १ is 1 (not 9), ४ is 4 (looks like a fancy 8), and ९ is 9 (looks like an English 3 gone wrong... or a 6 — it's 9).

Finally, punctuation. A Hindi sentence ends not with a period but with the **purnviram** । — a single vertical bar: मैं ठीक हूँ। *main Theek hoon*. [meh(n) Theek hoo(n)] I am fine. The question mark ? is used just as in English, and commas and quotation marks are the familiar Western ones.

DELHI STREET NOTE

Full assembly test, Delhi-style. Metro pillar: दिल्ली मेट्रो *dillee meTro* [dil-lee mayT-roh] — a geminate and a loanword. Dhaba board: शुद्ध शाकाहारी *shuddh shaakaahaaree* [shud-dh shah-kah-hah-ree] pure vegetarian — conjunct द्ध. Door sign: खींचो *kheencho* [khee(n)-choh] pull. If you can read those three cold, this chapter has done its job.

CHAPTER 10

Writing Devanagari I: Vowels & the First Rows

Writing cements reading — hands teach eyes. Ten minutes of tracing a day through weeks 1–4 and the script becomes yours. The general choreography for every letter:

1	Body first — draw the letter's curves and bowls, generally left to right, top to bottom.
2	Stem next — the vertical bar (if the letter has one) comes after the body.
3	Headline (शिरोरेखा) last — the horizontal roof is drawn LAST, in one stroke across the finished letter (across the whole word, once you write words).
4	Matras and dots after the roof — vowel signs, bindus and nuktas are the final garnish.

In each row below: copy the solid letter, trace the two gray ones, trace the faint one, then fill the empty boxes freehand. Slow beats pretty; pretty beats fast.

The vowels

अ and आ share a skeleton — आ just adds the tall bar. Master अ's S-curl first; half the alphabet borrows it. इ is one flowing hook; ई adds the overhead loop. उ/ऊ are single graceful curls. ए is a triangle-flag; ऐ adds one flick above.

अ	अ	अ	अ				
आ	आ	आ	आ				
इ	इ	इ	इ				
ई	ई	ई	ई				
उ	उ	उ	उ				

ऊ	ऊ	ऊ	ऊ				
ऋ	ऋ	ऋ	ऋ				
ए	ए	ए	ए				
ऐ	ऐ	ऐ	ऐ				
ओ	ओ	ओ	ओ				
औ	औ	औ	औ				
अं	अं	अं	अं				
अः	अः	अः	अः				

Row 1 — the क family (soft palate)

क is a loop crossed by the stem — draw the left loop, then the bar, roof last. ख is two chambers; don't let it collapse into ग-shapes. ग is the simplest — a hook and a stem. घ is ध's cousin — bowl, then stem. ङ is rare; one practice line is plenty.

क	क	क	क				
---	---	---	---	--	--	--	--

ख	ख	ख	ख				
ग	ग	ग	ग				
घ	घ	घ	घ				
ङ	ङ	ङ	ङ				

Row 2 — the च family (front dome)

च: bowl first, then stem. छ: the little moustache loop, then the circle, then stem. ज: zigzag then stem (झ is the same plus a dot below). झ: the trickiest of the five — practice the double-curve slowly.

च	च	च	च				
छ	छ	छ	छ				
ज	ज	ज	ज				
झ	झ	झ	झ				
ञ	ञ	ञ	ञ				

NOTE

Posture notes for all sheets: letters hang *from* the headline like laundry on a line — the roof touches the top of each letter. Keep every letter the same height; Devanagari's beauty is in its even skyline.

CHAPTER 11**Writing Devanagari II: The Rest, Digits & Whole Words****Row 3 — the ढ family (retroflex — curled sounds, curly letters)**

ढ is a simple open curl; ढ closes it into a circle-with-tail. ङ and ञ grow from the same spiral; ङ/ढ just add the dot below. ण: bowl + loop + stem.

ढ	ढ	ढ	ढ				
ढ	ढ	ढ	ढ				
ङ	ङ	ङ	ङ				
ढ	ढ	ढ	ढ				
ण	ण	ण	ण				
ङ	ङ	ङ	ङ				
ढ	ढ	ढ	ढ				

Row 4 — the त family (dental)

त: small loop then stem. थ: circle + stem — keep the circle round. द: one unbroken curl — practice it big first. ध: bowl then stem. न: hook then stem.

त	त	त	त				
थ	थ	थ	थ				
द	द	द	द				
ध	ध	ध	ध				
न	न	न	न				

Row 5 — the प family (lips)

प is an open bowl + stem; फ adds the outer loop (फ़ takes a dot below). ब/भ share the bowl — भ adds the inner curl. म: double-bump then stem.

प	प	प	प				
फ	फ	फ	फ				
ब	ब	ब	ब				
भ	भ	भ	भ				
म	म	म	म				

The soloists

य: open wave + stem. र: single elegant hook — no stem, no roof-length body. ल: double curl, tricky and lovely. व: व without the inner tick — mind the difference!

य	य	य	य				
र	र	र	र				
ल	ल	ल	ल				
व	व	व	व				

श: three-lobed; ष is श with a crossbar (rare in writing practice but you should recognize your own hand doing it). स: zigzag + stem. ह: the grand curl — practice big.

श	श	श	श				
ष	ष	ष	ष				
स	स	स	स				
ह	ह	ह	ह				

The nukta letters (Urdu guests)

Same bodies you already know, plus one dot tucked under the bowl. The dot is drawn last of all.

क	क	क	क				
ख	ख	ख	ख				
ग	ग	ग	ग				
ज	ज	ज	ज				
फ	फ	फ	फ				

Devanagari digits ०-९

You'll meet these on Delhi bus routes, temple boards and wedding cards. २ ३ are cousins of Western 2/3; ४ ५ ६ ७ are their own creatures.

०	०	०	०				
१	१	१	१				
२	२	२	२				
३	३	३	३				
४	४	४	४				

८	८	८	८				
६	६	६	६				
७	७	७	७				
८	८	८	८				
९	९	९	९				

Matra practice on क

Write the base क first, then place the matra: right · f LEFT (before the letter you just wrote — write क, then hook the f in front) · right with loop · below · above the roof · right plus above · dot above · moon-dot above.

का	का	का	का				
कि	कि	कि	कि				
की	की	की	की				
कु	कु	कु	कु				

कू	कू	कू	कू				
कृ	कृ	कृ	कृ				
के	के	के	के				
कै	कै	कै	कै				
को	को	को	को				
कौ	कौ	कौ	कौ				
कं	कं	कं	कं				
काँ	काँ	काँ	काँ				

Whole words — your first दिल्ली handwriting

Write all letter bodies first, left to right, then ONE headline stroke across the whole word, then matras and dots. Note the conjuncts: नमस्ते's स्ते and प्यार's प्या — half-letters lose their stem and lean on the next letter.

नमस्ते	नमस्ते	नमस्ते	
दिल्ली	दिल्ली	दिल्ली	

चाय	चाय	चाय	
प्यार	प्यार	प्यार	
हिन्दी	हिन्दी	हिन्दी	
धन्यवाद	धन्यवाद	धन्यवाद	
ठीक	ठीक	ठीक	
भैया	भैया	भैया	
पानी	पानी	पानी	
खाना	खाना	खाना	
घर	घर	घर	
शुक्रिया	शुक्रिया	शुक्रिया	

WITH YOUR PARTNER

Graduation exercise: handwrite a tiny note to your partner — their name in Devanagari + one word you like (चाय is always safe) — and get it stuck on the fridge. First artifact of your Hindi hands.

CHAPTER 12

Minimal-Pair Drills: Train Your Ear & Mouth

A minimal pair is two real words separated by exactly one sound — and Hindi's minimal pairs sit precisely on the contrasts English ignores: tooth-t versus curled-T, puff versus no puff, long vowel versus short, nasal versus plain, single consonant versus held double. If you can hear and produce the pairs in this chapter, you have the whole sound system. If you can't, no amount of vocabulary will save you from ordering a "branch" instead of lentils.

How to use this chapter: five minutes a day, out loud, for the rest of Book 1 — and keep coming back during Books 2–4. For each set: (1) read each pair aloud slowly, exaggerating the difference; (2) read the rows fast, alternating; (3) close your eyes while your partner says ONE word of a pair — point to the one you heard; (4) swap: you say one, your partner tells you which came out of your mouth. Step 4 is the only honest test.

WITH YOUR PARTNER

Partner quiz rules: no mercy and no mouthing. Delhi ears will give Jacob no benefit of the doubt at the sabzi stand, so the partner shouldn't either. Mark any pair that gets three passes in a row with a pencil tick; a pair with three ticks on different days is officially yours. The untickable ones — for most Americans that's दाल/डाल and काम/कम — get promoted to daily warm-up.

Set 1 — Dental t/d vs Retroflex T/D (tooth vs curl)

The king of contrasts. Lowercase = tongue tip on the back of the upper teeth; CAPITAL = tongue tip curled back; the underside taps the bumpy ridge behind the teeth. Remember: your automatic American t/d sounds retroflex to Indians, so the real work is forcing the dental.

PAIR	ROMAN	SAY IT	MEANINGS
दाल / डाल	<i>daal</i> (f) / <i>Daal</i> (f)	dahl / Dahl	lentils / tree branch
तन / टन	<i>tan</i> (m) / <i>Tan</i> (m)	tun / Tun	body / a ton
रोती / रोटी	<i>rotee</i> / <i>roTee</i> (f)	roh-tee / roh-Tee	(she) cries / flatbread
सूत / सूट	<i>soot</i> (m) / <i>sooT</i> (m)	soot / sooT	(spun) thread / a suit
कातना / काटना	<i>kaatnaa</i> / <i>kaaTnaa</i>	kaht-nah / kahT-nah	to spin (thread) / to cut

PAIR	ROMAN	SAY IT	MEANINGS
नाता / नाटा	<i>naataa</i> (m) / <i>naaTaa</i>	nah-tah / nah-Tah	family tie / short-statured
ताला / टाला	<i>taalaa</i> (m) / <i>Taalaa</i>	tah-lah / Tah-lah	a lock / put (it) off (past of <i>Taalnaa</i> , to postpone)
तीन / ठीक	<i>teen</i> / <i>Theek</i>	teen / Theek	three / fine — near pair : dental-plain vs retroflex-aspirated

WATCH OUT

English t/d live in no-man's-land between the two rows, and Indian ears assign them to the retroflex side. Practical rule: when you're not sure, go DENTAL — touch actual tooth. A too-dental त sounds charmingly careful; a retroflex त turns दाल *daal* [dahl] into firewood (डाल [Dahl]).

Set 2 — Aspirated vs Unaspirated (the puff)

Palm in front of your mouth for the left word: nothing. For the right word: a real burst. English can't help releasing a small puff on k/p/t at the start of words, so the hard half is the LEFT column — squeezing the puff to zero.

PAIR	ROMAN	SAY IT	MEANINGS
पल / फल	<i>pal</i> (m) / <i>phal</i> (m)	pul / phul	a moment / fruit
पूल / फूल	<i>pool</i> (m) / <i>phool</i> (m)	pool / phool	a (swimming) pool / flower
काना / खाना	<i>kaanaa</i> / <i>khaanaa</i> (m)	kah-nah / khah-nah	one-eyed / food; to eat
कील / खील	<i>keel</i> (f) / <i>kheel</i> (f)	keel / kheel	a nail / puffed rice (the Diwali offering)
तन / थन	<i>tan</i> (m) / <i>than</i> (m)	tun / thun	body / udder
बात / भात	<i>baat</i> (f) / <i>bhaat</i> (m)	baht / bhaht	talk, matter / cooked rice
चल / छल	<i>chal</i> / <i>chhal</i> (m)	chul / chhul	walk! move! / deceit

PAIR	ROMAN	SAY IT	MEANINGS
बाग / भाग	<i>baag</i> (m) / <i>bhaag</i>	bahg / bhahg	garden / run! — near pair (the final g's differ on paper, not in Delhi mouths)

NOTE

The voiced sighs (ब झ ढ ध भ) hide in that last row: भाग is not "b-hag" but one breathy syllable [bhahg]. If your partner hears two beats, you're adding a vowel — keep the voice humming straight through the release.

Set 3 — Short vs Long Vowels (length does the work)

Hindi has no stressed syllables to lean on; vowel LENGTH carries the meaning. Give long vowels a genuine double count — to an American ear the correct version always feels theatrically slow. The a/aa pairs are the beginner-killers: kam/kaam trips more learners than any retroflex ever will.

PAIR	ROMAN	SAY IT	MEANINGS
कम / काम	<i>kam</i> / <i>kaam</i> (m)	kum / kahm	less, little / work
दम / दाम	<i>dam</i> (m) / <i>daam</i> (m)	dum / dahm	breath / price
बल / बाल	<i>bal</i> (m) / <i>baal</i> (m)	bul / bahl	strength / hair
दिन / दीन	<i>din</i> (m) / <i>deen</i>	din / deen	day / poor, wretched
मिल / मील	<i>mil</i> / <i>meel</i> (m)	mil / meel	meet! (stem of <i>milnaa</i>) / a mile
पिता / पीता	<i>pitaa</i> (m) / <i>peetaa</i>	pi-tah / pee-tah	father / (he) drinks
चुकना / चूकना	<i>chuknaa</i> / <i>chooknaa</i>	chuk-nah / chook-nah	to be finished, used up / to miss (a chance)
पुल / पूल	<i>pul</i> (m) / <i>pool</i> (m)	pul / pool	bridge / a pool

DELHI STREET NOTE

Bonus triplet for the brave: पुल *pul* [pul] bridge · पूल *pool* [pool] pool · फूल *phool* [phool] flower. Length separates the first two, the puff separates the last two. Delhiites cross the ITO *pul* daily and will happily quiz you on all three in one breath.

Set 4 — Nasalized vs Plain Vowels (send it through the nose)

The (n) in the phonetics is never a spoken n — the vowel itself hums through the nose, French-style. Pinch your nostrils lightly: on the nasal word you should feel the buzz cut off.

PAIR	ROMAN	SAY IT	MEANINGS
सास / साँस	<i>saas</i> (f) / <i>saans</i> (f)	sahs / sah(n)s	mother-in-law / breath
कहा / कहाँ	<i>kahaa</i> / <i>kahaan</i>	kuh-hah / kuh-hah(n)	said / where
है / हैं	<i>hai</i> / <i>hain</i>	heh / heh(n)	is / are — you will say these hundreds of times a day
पूछ / पूँछ	<i>poochh</i> / <i>poonchh</i> (f)	poochh / poo(n)chh	ask! (stem of <i>poochhnaa</i>) / tail
गोद / गोंद	<i>god</i> (f) / <i>gond</i> (m)	gohd / goh(n)d	lap / glue
हँस / हंस	<i>hans</i> / <i>hans</i> (m)	huh(n)s / huns	laugh! / swan — moon-dot = pure nasal vowel; plain dot here = a real n

CULTURE

The saas/saans pair is a national institution: the mega-hit TV serial *Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi* lives on the saas (mother-in-law) side, and every Hindi speaker knows the joke that a bahu meeting her saas needs her saans. Get this pair right before dinner at the in-laws' — asking your सास [sahs] to catch her साँस [sah(n)s] will earn a laugh; mixing them up mid-sentence will earn a bigger one.

Set 5 — Single vs Double Consonants (hold the geminate)

A doubled (conjunct) consonant is genuinely held longer — close the mouth for the consonant, wait a beat, then release: put-tah. English does this across word boundaries ("bus stop", "book case"), never inside a word, so trust the hyphen in the phonetics.

PAIR	ROMAN	SAY IT	MEANINGS
पता / पत्ता	<i>pataa</i> (m) / <i>pattaa</i> (m)	puh-tah / put-tah	address; whereabouts / leaf
बचा / बच्चा	<i>bachaa</i> / <i>bachchaa</i> (m)	buh-chah / buch-chah	saved, left over / child

PAIR	ROMAN	SAY IT	MEANINGS
पका / पक्का	<i>pakaa / pakkaa</i>	puh-kah / puk-kah	ripe, cooked / firm, sure, pukka
गदा / गद्दा	<i>gadaa</i> (f) / <i>gaddaa</i> (m)	guh-dah / gud-dah	a mace (Hanuman's weapon) / mattress
दिली / दिल्ली	<i>dilee / dillee</i> (f)	di-lee / dil-lee	heartfelt (<i>dilee khvaahish</i> , a heartfelt wish) / Delhi
सच / सच्चा	<i>such</i> (m) / <i>sachchaa</i>	such / such-chah	truth / truthful — near pair (the ending differs too)

Set 6 — Loanword Sound Practice: ph vs f, j vs z

These two contrasts separate the native Hindi sounds from the Urdu-Persian-English layer of Delhi speech. Perfect minimal pairs are scarce here, so drill them as lists — left column pops, right column buzzes.

फ (p + puff) vs फ़ (true f)

LIPS POP: फ PH	SAY IT	TEETH BUZZ: फ़ F	SAY IT
फल <i>phal</i> (m) fruit	phul	फ़ोन <i>fon</i> (m) phone	fohn
फूल <i>phool</i> (m) flower	phool	फ़िल्म <i>film</i> (f) film	film
फिर <i>phir</i> again	phir	साफ़ <i>saaf</i> clean	sahf
फीका <i>pheekaa</i> bland	phee-kah	फ़र्क <i>farq</i> (m) difference	furk

DELHI STREET NOTE

Register note: plenty of Delhiites let native फ़ slide toward f too — you'll hear *fool* for फूल in fast speech, and nobody blinks. The reverse (saying *philm* for फ़िल्म) is heard as small-town. So: keep loanwords firmly f (*fon, film, farq*), and don't panic about the native words drifting.

ज (j) vs ज़ (z)

NATIVE: ज J	SAY IT	LOAN: ज़ Z	SAY IT
जो <i>jo</i> who, which	joh	ज़ोर <i>zor</i> (m) force	zohr
जान <i>jaan</i> (f) life; darling	jahn	ज़मीन <i>zameen</i> (f) ground, land	zuh-meen

NATIVE: ज J	SAY IT	LOAN: ज़ Z	SAY IT
जेब <i>jeb</i> (f) pocket	jayb	ज़रूर <i>zaroor</i> definitely	zuh-roor
जल्दी <i>jaldee</i> (f) hurry	jul-dee	जुकाम <i>zukaam</i> (m) head cold	zu-kahm

And one genuine minimal pair to seal it: सजा *sajaa* [suh-jah] decorated (from *sajnaa*) vs सज़ा *sazaa* (f) [suh-zah] punishment. A wedding hall is *sajaa*; a jail term is *sazaa*. Saying *jaroor* for ज़रूर is the single most-teased pronunciation slip in Hindi — one week with this list buys a lifetime of credibility.

Set 7 — श sh vs स s

Easy for English speakers to SAY — the trap is reading: श and स look nothing like sh and s, and your eye will swap them for months. Two real pairs, then a mixed list to read fast.

PAIR	ROMAN	SAY IT	MEANINGS
साल / शाल	<i>saal</i> (m) / <i>shaal</i> (f)	sahl / shahl	year / shawl
सेर / शेर	<i>ser</i> (m) / <i>sher</i> (m)	sayr / shayr	an old measure of weight / lion; couplet

Read aloud, alternating hisses: शहर *shehar* (m) [sheh-hur] city · सड़क *saRak* (f) [suh-Ruk] road · शादी *shaadee* (f) [shah-dee] wedding · समोसा *samosaa* (m) [suh-moh-sah] samosa · शीशा *sheeshaa* (m) [shee-shah] mirror, glass · सस्ता *sastaa* [sus-tah] cheap · शक *shak* (m) [shuk] doubt · स्टेशन *sTeshan* (m) [sTay-shun] station. Proverb-grade combo: सस्ती शादी *sastee shaadee* [sus-tee shah-dee] — a cheap wedding.

Practice Sentences: All Contrasts, Full Speed

Twelve natural sentences, each loaded with the contrasts above. Read the Devanagari; fall back on the Roman only when stuck. One run-through daily, and once a week have your partner pick three at random for a clean-pronunciation test.

आज काम कम है।

aaJ kaam kam hai. [ahj kahm kum heh]

There's not much work today. (kaam vs kam in one breath)

यह दाल है, वह डाल है।

yeh daal hai, voh Daal hai. [yeh dahl heh, voh Dahl heh]

This is daal; that is a branch.

ठंड में गरम दाल अच्छी लगती है।

ThanD mein garam daal achchhee lagtee hai. [ThunD may(n) guh-rum dahl uch-chhee lug-tee heh]
In the cold, hot daal feels wonderful.

बाग में फल और फूल हैं।

baag mein phal aur phool hain. [bahg may(n) phul awr phool heh(n)]
There are fruits and flowers in the garden.

सास ने लम्बी साँस ली।

saas ne lambee saans lee. [sahs nay lum-bee sah(n)s lee]
Mother-in-law took a long breath. (the classic — nail it before you meet yours)

बच्चा बड़ा सच्चा है।

bachchaa baRaa sachchaa hai. [buch-chah buh-Rah such-chah heh]
The kid is really truthful. (three geminates and a flap)

बच्ची रोती है क्योंकि रोटी ठंडी है।

bachchee rotee hai kyonki roTee ThanDee hai. [buch-chee roh-tee heh kyoh(n)-ki roh-Tee Thun-Dee heh]
The little girl is crying because the roti is cold. (rotee cries, roTee is bread)

स्टेशन एक मील दूर है।

sTeshan ek meel door hai. [sTay-shun ayk meel door heh]
The station is a mile away.

माँ ने नए साल पर शाल दी।

maan ne nae saal par shaal dee. [mah(n) nay nuh-ay sahl pur shahl dee]
Mom gave a shawl for New Year's. (saal vs shaal, plus a nasal maan)

पिता जी पानी पीते हैं।

pitaa jee paanee peete hain. [pi-tah jee pah-nee pee-tay heh(n)]
Father drinks water. (short i, long ee, back to back)

मुझे ज़रूर फ़ोन करना।

mujhe zaroor fon karnaa. [mu-jhay zuh-roor fohn kur-nah]
Do call me, for sure. (z and f — the Delhi essentials)

तुम्हारा घर कहाँ है?

tumhaaraa ghar kahaan hai? [tum-hah-rah ghur kuh-hah(n) heh]

Where is your house? (breathy gh, nasal kahaan)

NOTE

Progress check: record yourself reading all twelve sentences on day one of using this chapter, and again a month later. The difference will convince you of the method better than any teacher could. Then keep the daily five minutes going — pronunciation is a muscle, not a fact.

CHAPTER 13**Self-Tests, Partner Games & the Gauntlet**

Pronunciation only improves against feedback. This chapter is your feedback machine: a weekly solo protocol, four two-minute partner games, a set of twenty loaded sentences, and a troubleshooting table for when something keeps missing.

The weekly solo check (10 minutes, phone voice memo)

Every weekend: (1) record yourself reading the current week's ten flashcard words plus two gauntlet sentences; (2) do something else for an hour; (3) listen cold, next to the phonetic line. Fresh ears catch what busy ears excuse. Keep the recordings — replaying Week 2 during Week 10 is the single most motivating thing you can do in this course.

The four partner games

1 · Pointing pairs (trains your EAR)	Write the two target letters big on two papers (start with ढ/ट). Partner speaks random syllables or pair-words; you point. Ten right in a row = level up to the next pair set from Chapter 12. Two minutes.
2 · Which did I say? (trains your MOUTH)	Reverse roles: you speak a secretly-chosen item from a pair; partner writes down which they heard. Ten items, compare, score /10 in the tracker. The brutal, beautiful truth-teller.
3 · Shadow karaoke (trains your MELODY)	Partner voice-notes one natural sentence (their normal speed). You copy it until they certify "indistinguishable-ish." One line per session. These certified lines are your accent's trophy shelf.
4 · The vendor drill (trains REAL LIFE)	Partner plays a Delhi chai-vaalaa / auto-vaalaa / sabzi-vaalaa at 80% real speed, using this week's Book 4 dialogue as the script but improvising freely. You survive the transaction. Graduation: they go 100% speed and add background heckling.

The Gauntlet — twenty loaded sentences

Each sentence concentrates one target. Read down the list weekly; circle the numbers that still feel wobbly and drill just those. When all twenty pass the partner test, your pronunciation course is functionally complete.

1. भैया, दो कड़क चाय देना।

bhaiyaa, do kaRak chaay denaa. [bheh-yah, doh kuh-Ruk chah-ay day-nah]

Bhaiya, two strong chais. (bh + flap R)

2. ठीक है, थोड़ा ठंडा पानी दो।

Theek hai, thoRaa ThanDaa paanee do. [Theek heh, thoh-Rah Thun-Dah pah-nee doh]

Okay, give a little cold water. (Th vs th in one breath)

3. मैं दिल्ली में रहता हूँ।

main dillee mein rehtaa hoon. [meh(n) dil-lee may(n) reh-tah hoo(n)]

I live in Delhi. (nasals + geminate ll)

4. यह आटा बहुत अच्छा है।

yeh aaTaa bahut achchhaa hai. [yeh ah-Tah bo-hut uch-chhah heh]

This flour is very good. (retroflex T + chh)

5. मेरी सास साँस ले रही हैं।

meree saas saans le rahee hain. [may-ree sahs sah(n)s lay ruh-hee heh(n)]

My mother-in-law is taking a breath. (THE nasal pair)

6. लड़का सड़क पर दौड़ रहा है।

laRkaa saRak par dauR rahaa hai. [luhR-kah suh-Ruk pur dawR ruh-hah heh]

The boy is running on the road. (three flaps)

7. फल और फ़ोन मेज़ पर हैं।

phal aur fon mez par hain. [phul awr fohn mayz pur heh(n)]

The fruit and the phone are on the table. (ph vs f, z)

8. घर में धूप और भाप है।

ghar mein dhoop aur bhaap hai. [ghur may(n) dhoop awr bhahp heh]

There's sunshine and steam in the house. (gh dh bh trio)

9. काका कच्चा केला खाते हैं।

kaakaa kachchaa kelaa khaate hain. [kah-kah kuch-chah kay-lah khah-tay heh(n)]

Uncle eats raw banana. (k vs kh + geminate)

10. दादी दही और डबल रोटी लाई।

daadee dahee aur Dabal roTee laaen. [dah-dee duh-hee awr Duh-bul roh-Tee lah-ee(n)]

Grandma brought yogurt and bread. (d vs D vs T)

11. पत्ता कहाँ गिरा, पता नहीं।

pattaa kahaan giraa, pataa naheen. [put-tah kuh-hah(n) gi-rah, puh-tah nuh-hee(n)]

Where the leaf fell, no idea. (geminate vs single t)

12. तुम्हें ज़रूर मज़ा आएगा।

tumhen zaroor mazaa aaegaa. [tum-hay(n) zuh-roor muh-zah ah-ay-gah]

You'll definitely have fun. (true z's)

13. वह लड़की बड़ी समझदार है।

voh laRkee baRee samajhdaar hai. [voh luhR-kee buh-Ree suh-mujh-dahr heh]

That girl is very sensible. (flaps + schwa deletion)

14. क्या आप कल दिल्ली जाएँगे?

kyaa aap kal dillee jaaenge? [kyah ahp kul dil-lee jah-ay(n)-gay ʌ]

Will you go to Delhi tomorrow? (ky cluster + rising melody)

15. छोटे बच्चे छत पर हैं।

chhoTe bachche chhat par hain. [chhoh-Tay buch-chay chhut pur heh(n)]

The little kids are on the roof. (chh + geminate chch)

16. भाभी ने भिंडी बनाई है।

bhaabhee ne bhinDee banaaee hai. [bhah-bhee nay bhin-Dee buh-nah-ee heh]

Bhabhi has made okra. (double bh + nD)

17. ये कपड़े महँगे हैं।

ye kapRe mehnge hain. [yay kup-Ray mehn-gay heh(n)]

These clothes are expensive. (flap + nasal)

18. हाँ, मैं यहाँ हूँ ना।

haan, main yahaan hoon naa. [hah(n), meh(n) yuh-hah(n) hoo(n) nah]

Yes, I'm right here, na. (four nasals, one plain naa)

19. ऋषि को थोड़ी ठंड लग रही है।

rishi ko thoRee ThanD lag rahee hai. [ri-shi koh thoh-Ree Thun-D lug ruh-hee heh]

Rishi is feeling a bit cold. (th/Th again — the boss fight)

20. धन्यवाद, फिर मिलेंगे!

dhanyavaad, phir milenge! [dhun-yuh-vahd, phir mi-lay(n)-gay]

Thank you, see you again! (dh + ph, even syllables)

Troubleshooting: if they hear X, fix Y

SYMPTOM (PARTNER'S REPORT)	DIAGNOSIS	THE FIX
"Your ट sounds like त"	No curl — tip going straight up	Hold American "er" first, tap from the curl (Ch. 3)
"Your त sounds like ट/ English t"	Parked on the ridge	Touch the teeth — exaggerate forward till it feels silly
"कल and खल sound the same"	Puff too weak	Candle test; double the air on ख (Ch. 4)
"Everything sounds slightly puffed"	American initial-aspiration habit	Harvest the s-words: say "skin," drop the s, keep that क
"भ sounds like b-h, two sounds"	Voice stopping between b and h	Hum through it — one breathy gesture (Ch. 4)
"साँस sounds like सास"	Velum staying shut	Pinch-nose test; hum first, then vowel (Ch. 2)
"काम sounds like कम"	Long vowels too short	Two full beats on every aa/ee/oo — feel greedy about it
"Your ए sounds English ('day')"	Glide at the end	Freeze-hold 3 seconds, nothing moves (Ch. 2)
"ड sounds like र"	Flap starting uncurled	"Ladder" with a curled tip — slap, don't tap (Ch. 5)
"दिल्ली sounds like दिली"	Geminate not held	Park one silent beat on the double letter (Ch. 5)

Monthly milestones

MONTH	YOU CAN HONESTLY CHECK THIS WHEN...
1	☐ I read the whole alphabet aloud slowly · ☐ my ऋ/ॠ are different sounds in isolation · ☐ palm test passes on all five rows
2	☐ 8/10 on pointing-pairs (all Ch. 12 sets) · ☐ I read matra words without the roman line · ☐ nasal vowels on demand
3	☐ Gauntlet 1-10 partner-passed · ☐ schwa deletion automatic in words I know · ☐ I read Book 4 dialogue lines cold, slowly
4	☐ Gauntlet 11-20 partner-passed · ☐ partner understands new sentences without repeating ~70%
5	☐ 5 shadow-karaoke lines certified · ☐ I survive the vendor drill at full speed
6	☐ A stranger (real vendor / video call with family) understands me first try · ☐ I read a new paragraph aloud and my partner rates it "clearly understandable"